Between Civilisation and Constitution: Greek Parliamentary Debates on Gold Standard Adoption, 1875–1885

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Abstract

This paper reconstructs Greek parliamentary debates on gold standard adoption between 1875 and 1885 using newly digitised proceedings of the Hellenic Parliament. It argues that the gold standard — a regime that crystallised out of cumulative European policy practice rather than from a single founding theoretical text — nevertheless travelled to the Greek chamber as a model in Mary Morgan's sense, whose authority depended on narrative embedding as much as on technical demonstration. Parliamentary critics articulated fiscal fragility, distributional burden, premature convertibility, and constitutional impropriety as preconditions Greek conditions did not supply — preconditions whose immediate operational consequences the September 1885 suspension would shortly bear out — yet failed to command majorities in the decisive divisions reconstructed here because they lacked a counter-theory of peripheral gold adoption capable of rivalling the technical and civilisational bundle that Trikoupis's project offered. The paper extracts four observations from the parliamentary record and analyses them through Morgan's framework of model autonomy, narrative embedding, and travelling facts. It further argues that the critics did not need a counter-theory to argue against gold adoption in 1882–1885; what they needed was access to alternative justifications — "not now," "reform first," a different sequencing of LMU implementation, or Deligeorgis's gold-first unit reform — which were live in international monetary discourse but never assembled into propositions the Greek chamber could vote on. Both sides offered technical claims; the critics articulated the missing preconditions, while the government's technical case for adoption acquired authority through its bundling with a civilisational narrative that the critics could not match. The paper shows how parliamentary proceedings recover forms of situated economic knowledge that aggregate monetary histories systematically exclude.

Keywords: gold standard, Greece, parliamentary history, Mary Morgan, models as mediators, bimetallism, monetary history, history of economic thought

1 Introduction

On 14/26 November 1883, Prime Minister Charilaos Trikoupis rose in the Hellenic Parliament to defend his government's monetary policy. Greece, he declared, must lift forced circulation and move towards gold because doing so would attract capital, restore money to the value recognised by the world market, rescue the country's economic position, bring Greece "into line with the other civilised states," and make it the "Stock Exchange of the East."[1] The speech was characteristic of Trikoupis's approach. He framed technical monetary policy as a question of national honour, European identity, and access to international capital markets.

Yet within months of restoration, the achievement he celebrated had collapsed. Greece restored convertibility in early 1885, only to suspend it in September of the same year when the military mobilisation following Bulgaria's annexation of Eastern Rumelia compounded fiscal pressures that had been accumulating since late 1884. By October 1885, the legal ambiguities of forced circulation had become a parliamentary controversy: Trikoupis called the relevant clause extraordinarily obscure, while Balsamakis warned that indeterminate rules would generate "innumerable lawsuits" over paper-money obligations.[2] By 1/13 December 1893, Trikoupis was introducing bankruptcy legislation to Parliament in explicit acknowledgement that the Greek state could no longer service its external obligations.[3]

1. Trikoupis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 8, 14/26 November 1883. The peroration is uninterrupted across twelve lines and bundles the technical and civilisational claims in a single rhetorical unit: ('we shall bring Greece into the parallel of the other civilised States, we shall save the economic condition of the country, and we shall make it the Stock Exchange of the East through the lifting of forced circulation'). The technical mechanism is supplied in the same passage: ('Capital comes only where the currency has the value recognised by the general market of the world'). Trikoupis frames the abolition of forced circulation as an act of recovery rather than aggression: ('the lifting of forced circulation will open an asylum to it [capital]'). The English "into line with the other civilised states" is a fair rendering of the Greek phrase, though the geometric metaphor ('into the parallel of') is sharper than the idiomatic English suggests, and consistent with the engineering-register vocabulary (foundations and edifice) that runs through the rest of the speech.

2. Trikoupis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 12, 24 October/5 November 1885: ('nothing is more unclear than the clause under discussion…the unclarity of the clause is the greatest'). The English "extraordinarily obscure" is a paraphrase of the comparative-and-superlative construction, not a verbatim translation. Balsamakis, same session: ('This discussion was prompted in order to forestall the lawsuits which are likely to arise before the courts as a result of the indeterminacy of the term in the Royal Decree…so that innumerable lawsuits should be generated'). Dragoumis, same session, made an analogous complaint: ('there is great unclarity and ambiguity'), indicating that the obscurity reading was shared across opposition speakers in the chamber.

3. The traditional attribution of the phrase ("unfortunately, we have gone bankrupt́) to Trikoupis in a formal declaration of 10 December 1893 is substantively misleading. Trikoupis introduced the bankruptcy bill (Provisional Regulation of the Public Debt Service) on 1/13 December 1893, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 25, with the bill text printed in the parliamentary *Supplement* of the same parliamentary period. The canonical phrase itself does not appear in the published proceedings journal and, on the authoritative reading of the parliamentary-records editor, was probably not uttered from the podium at all; it is more likely an opposition-attributed formulation that reached historiography through memoir literature (notably Andreas Syngros's *Memoirs*) and the political press of late 1893, with "10 December 1893" representing a retrospective assignment of the legislative date of the bankruptcy law to the spoken declaration. See Flerianou (*Charilaos Trikoupis: i zoi kai to ergo tou [Charilaos Trikoupis: His Life and Work]*), vol. I, for the archival reading, Tricha (*Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politicos tou "Tis Ptaiei" kai tou "Dystychos Eptochevsamen" [Charilaos Trikoupis: The Politician of "Who's to Blame?" and "Regretfully, We Are Bankrupt"]*, 509–558) for the political context (page range as identified in Aliprantis ("Review of Lydia Tricha, *Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politikos tou 'Tis Ptaiei?' kai tou 'Dystychos Eptochevsamen'*")), and Gallant (*The Edinburgh History of the Greeks, 1768 to 1913: The Long Nineteenth Century*) for the broader

This sequence frames the paper's central puzzle. Parliamentarians who warned against Trikoupis's project proved predictively accurate in several specific respects: fiscal weakness did undermine convertibility in 1885, steeply discounted foreign loans did burden the treasury, and the rush to join the gold club did produce instability rather than stability. Yet in the decisive divisions reconstructed here, they failed to command a majority in Parliament. Why did predictively accurate, locally informed arguments fail to persuade?

The existing literature on Greek monetary history provides structural explanations, and the economists-in-parliament literature identifies parliamentary economic actors, but neither reconstructs the 1875–1885 gold-standard debates as contests over sequencing, rhetoric, coalition structure, and model authority. Sophia Lazaretou has demonstrated that fiscal vulnerability and the subordination of monetary policy to treasury needs made gold standard adherence precarious from the start.[4] Matthias Morys has situated Greece within the broader pattern of core-periphery dynamics in the Balkans, showing that the gold standard worked through a five-stage sequence of adoption, suspension, international control, institutional reform, and eventual stabilisation.[5] Michalis Psalidopoulos and Adamantios Syrmaloglou have identified Greek parliamentary economic actors and their views on fiscal and monetary policy across the longer 1862–1910 period.[6]

But these accounts work mainly from aggregate data, published treatises, diplomatic correspondence, and selective parliamentary evidence. They tell us what experts thought and what structural constraints obtained, but they do not reconstruct the proceedings as sustained parliamentary contests over sequencing, rhetoric, coalition structure, and model authority.

This paper reconstructs the Greek parliamentary debates on gold standard adoption using newly digitised proceedings from 1875 to 1885. Parliamentary dates are given Old Style (Julian)/New Style (Gregorian), following the convention standard in Greek historiography of this period. The digitised proceedings used here do not preserve printed-page markers from Ἐφημερὶς τῶν Συζητήσεων τῆς Βουλῆς; all parliamentary citations are therefore given by session and dual date only. It treats the gold standard not as a self-enforcing commitment mechanism but as a model that required institutional mediation, specifically parliamentary assent, that was never fully secured. The gold standard treated here is the practice-derived regime that cumulative Eu-

political setting of the 1893 crisis.

4. Sophia Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949," in *South-Eastern European Monetary and Economic Statistics from the Nineteenth Century to World War II*, Chapter page range approximate — corpus text dump ends p. 138. (Athens, Sofia, Bucharest, and Vienna: Bank of Greece, Bulgarian National Bank, National Bank of Romania, / Oesterreichische Nationalbank, 2014).

5. Matthias Morys, "Monetary Integration in the Balkans, 1870–1914," *Journal of European Economic History* 35, no. 2 (2006): 333–363; Matthias Morys, "A Century of Monetary Reform in South-East Europe: From Political Autonomy to the Gold Standard, 1815–1910," Special issue: Financial and Monetary History of South-East Europe, *Financial History Review* 24, no. 1 (April 2017): 3–21; Matthias Morys, "The Gold Standard, Fiscal Dominance and Financial Supervision in Greece and South-East Europe, 1841–1939," Advance access: 19 May 2020, *European Review of Economic History* 25, no. 1 (February 2021): 106–136.

6. Michalis Psalidopoulos and Adamantios Syrmaloglou, "Economists in the Greek Parliament, 1862–1910: The Men and Their Views on Fiscal and Monetary Policy," in *Economists in Parliament in the Liberal Age (1848–1920): A Comparative Perspective*, ed. Massimo M. Augello and Marco E. L. Guidi (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2005), 229–258.

ropean state experience had crystallised into a transmissible monetary architecture by the late 1870s, not a textbook theoretical construct; §2.3 below addresses the asymmetry between this object and the theory-first models with which Morgan's framework is most often associated, and explains why the application is consistent with — and indeed a sharper test of — the framework's own claim that models are constructed from heterogeneous materials.[7] In doing so, the paper asks what Mary Morgan's "models as mediators" framework reveals when applied not to the economist's workshop, but to the deliberative institutions where models must win political authority to reshape the world.[8]

The argument proceeds in seven sections. Section II reviews the literature on Greek monetary history, establishes bimetallism as the primary available alternative to gold monometallism, addresses the asymmetry between the practice-derived gold standard and the theory-first models with which Morgan's framework is most often associated, and introduces Morgan's theoretical framework. Section III provides the historical context necessary to follow the debates. Section IV reconstructs the parliamentary proceedings themselves, organised around three main episodes: the coinage and sequencing disputes of 1875–1882 (covering both the early bronze coin crisis and the intermediate debates), the 170 million franc loan debates of 1882–1885, and the collapse of September–December 1885. Section V extracts four observations from the parliamentary record and connects them to Morgan's framework: it analyses the failure of bimetallism to become a counter-narrative, maps the structure of parliamentary criticism across factions and registers, and distinguishes the paper's claim — that the critics articulated alternative justifications which never reached programmatic form in the chamber — from the stronger claims that gold standard theory or the gold standard model were simply wrong. Section VI analyses why the critics lost even though later events confirmed many of their warnings, drawing on Morgan's concepts of model autonomy, narrative embedding, and the travelling facts problem. Section VII concludes by reflecting on what the Greek case reveals about the relationship between economic ideas and political institutions, and identifies extensions for future research.

The paper makes two claims. For monetary history, it shows that parliamentary proceedings reveal arguments about regional equity, constitutional propriety, and distributional burden that aggregate analysis systematically excludes. For the history of economic thought, it argues that when models travel to peripheral parliaments, locally grounded objections can fail even when later events bear out their warnings, because they lack a counter-theory capable of rivalling the

7. Giulio M. Gallarotti, *The Anatomy of an International Monetary Regime: The Classical Gold Standard, 1880–1914* (New York and Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995); Marc Flandreau, *The Glitter of Gold: France, Bimetallism, and the Emergence of the International Gold Standard, 1848–1873*, Translated from French: *L'or du monde: la France et la stabilité du système monétaire international, 1848–1873* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004); Margaret Morrison and Mary S. Morgan, "Models as Mediating Instruments," in *Models as Mediators: Perspectives on Natural and Social Science*, ed. Mary S. Morgan and Margaret Morrison (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 10–37.

8. Mary S. Morgan and Margaret Morrison, *Models as Mediators: Perspectives on Natural and Social Science* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999); Mary S. Morgan, *The World in the Model: How Economists Work and Think* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012).

travelling model's authority. The critics had predictively accurate arguments. They did not have a counter-theory of how peripheral gold adoption could work under Greek conditions.

2 Literature and Framework

2.1 Greek Monetary History and the Gold Standard Periphery

The modern literature on Greek monetary history begins with Sophia Lazaretou's systematic reconstruction of the nineteenth-century experience.[9] Her central finding is that Greece's engagement with the gold standard was shaped by what Morys has termed fiscal dominance, the subordination of monetary policy to the treasury's financing needs.[10] Unlike the core economies of Western Europe, where central banks could prioritise price stability, the National Bank of Greece operated as a "universal bank"—in Lazaretou's characterisation—that held the exclusive privilege of note issue and functioned simultaneously as a commercial lender and provider of government finance.[11]

This fiscal vulnerability produced what Lazaretou describes as an "escape clause" for war emergencies: Greece's adherence to metallic convertibility was conditional on fiscal circumstances, suspended whenever wartime or deficit pressures mounted.[12][13] Between 1828 (counting from the phoenix monetary system of the Kapodistrias government, which preceded both the drachma and formal international recognition of Greek independence) and 1936, Greece suspended convertibility eight times.[14][15] The pattern was predictable: foreign loans would flow in during periods of optimism, the government would restore convertibility to signal creditworthiness, and then a crisis, whether military, fiscal, or external, would force suspension. In Bordo and Rockoff's terms, the gold standard operated in Greece as a "good housekeeping seal," but one applied without the underlying fiscal housekeeping the metaphor assumes: convertibility was restored to signal creditworthiness rather than to reflect it, making the seal insufficiently

9. Sophia Lazaretou, "Monetary and Fiscal Policies in Greece: 1833–1914," *Journal of European Economic History* 22, no. 2 (1993): 285–311.

10. Morys, "The Gold Standard, Fiscal Dominance and Financial Supervision in Greece and South-East Europe, 1841–1939."

11. Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949," 103.

12. Sophia Lazaretou, "The Drachma, Foreign Creditors, and the International Monetary System: Tales of a Currency during the 19th and the Early 20th Centuries," *Explorations in Economic History* 42, no. 2 (2005): 202–236; Sophia Lazaretou, "Government Spending, Monetary Policies, and Exchange Rate Regime Switches: The Drachma in the Gold Standard Period," *Explorations in Economic History* 32, no. 1 (1995): 28–50.

13. Lazaretou's application of the "rule with escape clauses" framework to Greece is set out most fully in her 2005 *Explorations in Economic History* article, building on the empirical analysis of regime switches in Lazaretou (1995); the SEEMHN chapter (p. 105, fn. 12) carries the same attribution.

14. Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949," 101.

15. Lazaretou's Table 1 (pp. 105–106) lists nine episodes; the ninth (April 1941, under Axis occupation) falls outside the 1828–1936 window specified in the prose count.

backed to function as a genuine commitment mechanism.[16][17][18] Yet Lazaretou's account, focused on macroeconomic aggregates and institutional structures, leaves unexplored how Greek politicians understood and contested the gold standard's promises and risks.

Matthias Morys has placed the Greek case within the broader context of Balkan monetary integration, most systematically in his 2021 analysis of fiscal dominance and financial supervision across South-East Europe from 1841 to 1939.[19] His five-stage descriptive account of adoption, suspension, international control, institutional reform, and eventual stabilisation, developed most explicitly in his 2017 study of monetary reform in the region,[20] captures the trajectory not just of Greece but of Serbia, Bulgaria, and Romania.[21] The key variable was not the technical requirements of gold adherence but the degree of fiscal discipline that international creditors could impose. Where the International Financial Commission exercised supervision over fiscal policy, as in Greece after 1898, monetary stabilisation was gradually achieved through the withdrawal of excessive notes in circulation.[22] But Morys's model, while illuminating the structural constraints, does not reconstruct the parliamentary exchanges through which adoption, suspension, and international control were debated, justified, and contested.

Michalis Psalidopoulos and Adamantios Syrmaloglou have identified the parliamentary presence of Greek economic actors and their views on fiscal and monetary policy between 1862 and 1910.[23] Read cautiously, this prosopographical literature points less to sustained theoretical abstraction in parliament than to practical and administrative reasoning about taxation, credit, monetary management, and short-term government finance.[24] Separately, Stassinopoulos shows that British disputes between the Currency and Banking Schools reached Greece in adapted form, with Banking School arguments finding particular resonance in a capital-starved

16. Michael D. Bordo and Hugh Rockoff, "The Gold Standard as a "Good Housekeeping Seal of Approval"," *Journal of Economic History* 56, no. 2 (1996): 389–428.

17. Bordo and Rockoff's 1996 sample covered nine peripheral economies (Argentina, Australia, Brazil, Canada, Chile, Italy, Portugal, Spain, and the United States) and did not include Greece. The application of the 'good housekeeping' framework to the Greek case in this paragraph is the paper's extension of their concept, not a claim they make.

18. The terms "credible commitment" and "commitment mechanism" are used here in the historiographical sense developed by Bordo and Rockoff and the subsequent literature on rules versus discretion in monetary history. They are modern analytical categories, not concepts available to nineteenth-century actors; the paper is careful throughout not to attribute them to the parliamentarians themselves. The same applies to "signalling" where it appears in subsequent analysis.

19. Morys, "The Gold Standard, Fiscal Dominance and Financial Supervision in Greece and South-East Europe, 1841–1939."

20. Morys, "A Century of Monetary Reform in South-East Europe: From Political Autonomy to the Gold Standard, 1815–1910."

21. Morys's stage account is a historian's retrospective typology, not a theoretical framework available to contemporaries. It identifies a recurring pattern visible only with hindsight from outcomes. The Greek parliamentarians of the 1870s–1880s could not have known they were at "step one" of a sequence that would culminate in international financial control and eventual stabilisation after 1898. When the paper later refers to Morys's "model," it does so in the loose descriptive sense of a stages account; no claim about predictive or theoretical status is intended.

22. Ali Coşkun Tunçer, *Sovereign Debt and International Financial Control: The Middle East and the Balkans, 1868–1914* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015).

23. Psalidopoulos and Syrmaloglou, "Economists in the Greek Parliament, 1862–1910: The Men and Their Views on Fiscal and Monetary Policy."

24. Psalidopoulos and Syrmaloglou, 229–258.

setting.[25] But these accounts remain at the level of ideas, actors, and positions; they do not reconstruct the rhetorical strategies through which those ideas won or lost in parliamentary contest.

A complementary intellectual history has recently been supplied by Michalis Sotiropoulos's reconstruction of Greek liberalism in the long nineteenth century, which argues that liberal political thought in post-revolutionary Greece operated as a practical mode of statecraft rather than as a derivative imitation of European templates, and preserved a radical edge precisely where elsewhere in Europe liberalism was losing it.[26] The civilisational narrative whose parliamentary deployment this paper reconstructs sits inside that broader liberal-statecraft frame: Trikoupis's appeal to "the parallel of the other civilised States" was not generic European mimicry but a specific operationalisation of Greek liberalism's Europeanising current — one that the more conservative or particularist strands within the same liberal tradition could in principle have contested but did not, in the parliamentary monetary register, organise to do so. Reading the gold-standard debates inside Sotiropoulos's frame helps make visible why the chamber's available counter-narratives were thinner than the simple availability of bimetallism abroad would predict: the liberal-statecraft idiom in which monetary modernisation was being conducted was itself the deeper resource the critics would have needed to contest, and it was not the kind of resource a parliamentary speech against a particular loan or coinage measure could displace.

One further absence in the existing literature deserves notice: the international debate over bimetallism. Throughout the 1870s and 1880s, the gold standard faced a serious and well-organised rival in the form of bimetallism, the proposal to maintain fixed legal ratios between gold and silver so that both metals circulated as monetary standards. This was not a fringe position. The Latin Monetary Union, to which Greece had acceded in 1867, had originally been built on a bimetallic foundation, and the accelerating depreciation of silver after 1873, associated with Germany's demonetisation of silver and with the distinct US controversy triggered by the Coinage Act of 1873, made the choice between gold and silver a live political question across Europe and the Americas. In France, economists and politicians associated with the bimetallic tradition argued vigorously that a return to gold alone would impose deflationary costs and transfer resources from debtor to creditor nations. In the United States, the controversy was if anything more intense: the Bland-Allison Act of 1878 and the Sherman Silver Purchase Act of 1890 reflected the political strength of silver interests, and the debate culminated in William Jennings Bryan's "Cross of Gold" speech at the Democratic National Convention in 1896. By the mid-1880s, when the Greek debates examined in this paper reached their climax, bimetallism was a leading theoretical alternative to gold monometallism available in international economic discourse.[27]

25. Yiorgos Stassinopoulos, "Economic Thought and Monetary Policy in Nineteenth-Century Greece," in *Economic Thought and Policy in Less Developed Europe: The Nineteenth Century*, ed. Michalis Psalidopoulos and Maria Eugénia Mata (London and New York: Routledge, 2002), 172–186.

26. Michalis Sotiropoulos, *Liberalism after the Revolution: The Intellectual Foundations of the Greek State, c. 1830–1880*, Ideas in Context 143 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023).

27. Flandreau, *The Glitter of Gold: France, Bimetallism, and the Emergence of the International Gold Standard, 1848–1873*; Milton Friedman, "Bimetallism Revisited," *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 4, no. 4 (1990):

That availability did not mean that every Greek economic critic was a latent bimetallist. Economos is the clearest case: Psalidopoulos reconstructs him as an opponent of the Latin Monetary Union agreement, of state borrowing, and of the National Bank's privileges, but also as a defender of monometallism against bimetallism once silver depreciation made dual standards vulnerable to speculation.[28] Valassopoulos likewise appears in the parliamentary-economist literature as a fiscal and developmental reformer, arguing in 1880 for income taxation, infrastructure, railways, and cooperative agricultural credit rather than for a silver or bimetallic standard.[29] These off-stage positions sharpen the puzzle rather than dissolve it: Greek economic literacy and reformist critique existed, but the available international bimetallist language did not become an on-stage parliamentary counter-model.

2.2 Morrison's Challenge: Confused Technical Beliefs as a Third Path

James Ashley Morrison's account of Britain's 1925 return to gold poses the strongest comparative challenge to the binary that this paper risks drawing between civilisational narrative and technical criticism.[30] In Morrison's reconstruction, the return to prewar parity was explained neither by a straightforward political-economy capture story, in which banking interests or a Treasury-City nexus simply imposed their material preferences, nor by pure rhetorical performance. The decisive force was technically sophisticated reasoning built on mistaken beliefs about how the pre-1914 gold standard had actually operated. The Cunliffe Committee's 1918 report is Morrison's central exhibit: its account mythologised the classical gold standard as an automatic system of price-specie-flow adjustment that could be restored if Britain returned to the old parity and re-established the proper monetary rules.[31] The Macmillan Committee's 1931 report then provides retrospective evidence that this framework had failed under interwar conditions, but also that its conceptual hold remained powerful even as policy makers confronted the costs of defending sterling.[32]

Morrison's strongest empirical move is to show that the politics of return cannot be reduced to material interests. Even Labour and the trade unions, actors who stood to bear the costs of deflation and unemployment, supported return to gold because they accepted the causal belief that gold was the cornerstone of price stability and the only reliable bulwark against hyperinflation.

85–104; Angela Redish, *Bimetallism: An Economic and Historical Analysis*, Studies in Macroeconomic History (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000); Luca Einaudi, *Money and Politics: European Monetary Unification and the International Gold Standard, 1865–1873* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001).

28. Michalis Psalidopoulos, *A History of Modern Greek Economic Thought* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2024), 78–81.

29. Psalidopoulos, 58.

30. James Ashley Morrison, *England's Cross of Gold: Keynes, Churchill, and the Governance of Economic Beliefs* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2021); James Ashley Morrison, "Shocking Intellectual Austerity: The Role of Ideas in the Demise of the Gold Standard in Britain," *International Organization* 70, no. 1 (2016): 175–207.

31. Great Britain. Committee on Currency and Foreign Exchanges after the War, *First Interim Report of the Committee on Currency and Foreign Exchanges after the War*, Cd. 9182, 1918.

32. Great Britain. Committee on Finance and Industry, *Report of the Committee on Finance and Industry*, Cmd. 3897, 1931.

That alignment cuts hard against rationalist interest-group accounts: if actors moved against their apparent distributive interests, the explanation must include the causal ideas through which those interests became legible. Morrison therefore identifies a third path between interest-group capture and empty symbolism: sophisticated but confused technical belief.

The misconceptions Morrison reconstructs are precise. First, British orthodoxy treated the price-specie-flow mechanism as automatic, rather than as a system historically dependent on discretionary central-bank management and international cooperation. Second, it sustained the myth of the Bank of England as the conductor of the international orchestra, capable of coordinating global adjustment through the Bank Rate. Third, it treated 1870–1914 as a single proven, rule-governed system rather than a contingent configuration of institutions, credibility, empire, capital flows, and diplomatic cooperation. Fourth, it made leaving gold nearly synonymous with hyperinflation, thereby foreclosing alternatives epistemically before they could be evaluated politically.

This places Morrison in a different position from the standard interwar accounts against which this paper has so far leaned. Against Eichengreen's emphasis on the ideological grip of the gold standard mentality and the failures of interwar central-bank cooperation, Morrison drills further to reconstruct the specific technical misconceptions about the prewar system that made gold seem compulsory.[33] Against Boyce's account of interwar reconstruction and the City-centred structure of British capitalism, Morrison shows that the City-interests story is underdetermined unless we explain why actors outside that constituency also accepted gold as necessary.[34] The implication for the Greek case is direct: the opposition between narrative justification and predictively accurate criticism may itself be too simple. The government's defenders may have been operating with a technical model that was not merely rhetorical, while the critics may have lacked not just a counter-narrative but a counter-theory of peripheral gold adoption.

A small "economists in parliament" literature suggests why this omission matters. Frank Whitson Fetter traced how political economy entered British legislative life from the late eighteenth century, Barry Gordon reconstructed parliamentary uses of Ricardian language in the debates of 1819–1823, and Massimo Augello and Marco Guidi have shown comparatively how economists and economic reasoning were institutionalised within liberal-era parliaments.[35] Yet this literature has focused chiefly on economists as parliamentary actors and on comparative prosopography. It has had less to say about what happens when a travelling monetary model is authorised, resisted, and transformed inside a peripheral legislature.

33. Barry Eichengreen, *Golden Fetters: The Gold Standard and the Great Depression, 1919–1939* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992).

34. Robert W. D. Boyce, *British Capitalism at the Crossroads, 1919–1932: A Study in Politics, Economics, and International Relations* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988).

35. Frank Whitson Fetter, *The Economist in Parliament, 1780–1868* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1980); Barry Gordon, *Political Economy in Parliament, 1819–1823* (London: Macmillan, 1976); Massimo M. Augello and Marco E. L. Guidi, eds., *Economists in Parliament in the Liberal Age (1848–1920): A Comparative Perspective* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2005).

What remains missing is a debate-level account of how the gold standard model was defended, contested, and transformed in the legislative arena during the decisive 1875–1885 sequence. The existing literature tells us that fiscal dominance constrained Greek monetary policy, that international supervision eventually imposed discipline, and that Greek economists engaged with European debates; this paper asks how those ideas acquired, or failed to acquire, parliamentary authority in the votes and exchanges that made policy.

2.3 A Model that Grew out of Practice

Before applying Morgan's framework to the Greek case, one structural feature of the gold standard as an object of analysis must be addressed directly. Unlike growth theory, where Solow's 1956 paper can be identified as the moment a working theoretical model entered the discipline and then travelled outward into policy use, the international gold standard has no equivalent founding text. It emerged from a cumulative sequence of national policy choices — Britain's de facto adherence from the early eighteenth century and de jure from 1821, Germany's 1871–73 demonetisation of silver, France's 1873 limitation of silver coinage, and the Latin Monetary Union's 1860s arrangements — whose collective effect crystallised into an international regime only retrospectively. The gold standard was a practice that hardened into a model, not a model that descended into practice.

Recent scholarship makes this point explicitly. Gallarotti's analysis of the classical regime treats its emergence as a decentralised process driven by converging incentives — the symbolic status of gold, industrialisation and economic development, the politics of metallic standards, and liberal economic ideology — rather than by theoretical demonstration or coordinated central-bank cooperation.[36] Eichengreen and Flandreau's editorial framing of the same period juxtaposes "theory" and "history" precisely because the regime cannot be reconstructed from theory alone.[37] Flandreau's account of the 1873 turning point shows that the gold standard's emergence was contingent on a specific French policy choice (the September 1873 limitation of silver coinage), not on the theoretical superiority of monometallism over the bimetallic alternative that contemporaries treated as fully viable.[38]

This raises a real question for the framework. If Morgan's "models as mediators" account is built on cases like Irving Fisher's hydraulic model of the monetary system, where a self-conscious theoretical construction crosses into policy use, does it still apply to a regime that travelled in the opposite direction — from policy into model? The answer is that it does, and that the Greek case is in fact a particularly clean test of it. Morgan's framework is explicit that models are constructed from *heterogeneous* materials — theoretical concepts, mathematical structures, empirical regularities, analogies, institutional arrangements, and policy consid-

36. Gallarotti, *The Anatomy of an International Monetary Regime: The Classical Gold Standard, 1880–1914*.

37. Barry Eichengreen and Marc Flandreau, eds., *The Gold Standard in Theory and History*, Second (London and New York: Routledge, 1997).

38. Flandreau, *The Glitter of Gold: France, Bimetallism, and the Emergence of the International Gold Standard, 1848–1873*.

erations — so a model whose construction draws disproportionately from accumulated policy experience is consistent with, not anomalous to, the framework.[39] What matters for the framework's application is not whether the model originated in theory or in practice, but whether by the moment of *travel* it had acquired the autonomous, demonstration-capable, narrative-bearing character that lets it function as a mediating instrument in a new institutional setting. By the 1875–1885 Greek debates, the gold standard had acquired exactly that character: it could be "run" discursively to demonstrate creditworthiness, capital inflow, and civilisational alignment, even though no Greek (and few European) parliamentarians could point to a single canonical theoretical text. It is the model's autonomy at the moment of travel, not the genealogy of its construction, that the framework requires. The Greek case is therefore a test of whether Morgan's framework can illuminate model travel under the harder condition of practice-derived models, not a misuse of a framework designed for textbook theoretical objects.

2.4 Models, Mediation, and Parliamentary Authority

Before turning to Morgan's framework, one distinction must be kept in view throughout the analysis: the difference between historians' retrospective accounts and the theoretical resources available to contemporaries. Morys's stages account and Lazaretou's fiscal dominance thesis are analytical constructs built from outcomes that were not visible to participants at the time. The Greek parliamentarians of the 1870s and 1880s had access to a different, and in some ways thinner, set of resources: European political economy, the British Currency and Banking School controversy as adapted in Greek debate, the practical experience of neighbouring countries with metallic standards, the public balance sheets of the National Bank, and whatever they could read in European financial journalism. When we ask why the critics lost, we must be careful not to credit them, or their opponents, with the superior knowledge that hindsight provides. The paper accordingly distinguishes throughout between what the historical actors could have known and what we, as historians, can see they were failing to anticipate.

Mary Morgan's "models as mediators" framework provides the analytical tools to fill this gap. Developed with Margaret Morrison in their 1999 edited volume, the framework argues that scientific models occupy a distinctive position in the theory-world relationship: they are neither pure theory nor raw data, but semi-autonomous objects that "shuttle between" both domains.[40] Morgan's subsequent work has applied this framework to economists' workshops, policy laboratories, and sites of model construction. But parliamentary settings, where models must win political authority to reshape economies, remain underexplored. Applying Morgan's framework to legislative deliberation is thus both an extension and a test of its explanatory reach.

The framework rests on three key concepts. First, *autonomy*: models are constructed from heterogeneous materials (theoretical concepts, mathematical structures, empirical data, analo-

39. Morrison and Morgan, "Models as Mediating Instruments," 10–37.
40. Morrison and Morgan, 10–37.

gies, and policy considerations) that cannot all be derived from a single source.[41] Because no one theory fully dictates a model's construction, the model develops its own internal logic and constraints. Second, *mediation*: because models are autonomous, they can function as "instruments of investigation" that probe both theory and the world.[42] Third, *narrative*: Morgan's later work shows that models gain authority not just through formal proof but through the stories they tell, narratives that link the abstract world of the model to concrete economic circumstances.[43] Economists use models by telling exploratory stories about what happens within them, and narrative becomes the device that carries model-based reasoning outward into institutional settings.[44]

For the Greek case, the crucial insight concerns what Morgan calls the "travelling facts" problem.[45] When a model travels from its site of construction to a new institutional context, from the economist's workshop to the parliamentary chamber, it carries with it a bundle of resources: theoretical authority, narrative framing, and technical demonstration. Local objections that challenge the model's formal apparatus may fail because they lack the model's narrative embedding. In Morgan's terms, a successful contestation requires not just logical refutation but a rival mediating instrument, a counter-model that can demonstrate what the world would look like under an alternative policy.[46]

For shorthand, the paper treats model construction, interrogation, and demonstration as Steps 1–3, and narrative contestation as Step 4.

These four steps are necessary but not sufficient for the analysis the parliamentary record requires. Three further distinctions, often collapsed in writing on the gold standard and at risk of being collapsed here, must be kept separate.

A *counter-theory* is a rival causal account of how a monetary regime will produce its effects under specified conditions. To advance a counter-theory of peripheral gold adoption is to claim, with reasons, that adoption under Greek conditions will produce different effects from adoption under British or French conditions, and to specify the mechanism. Bimetallism, in its 1880s

41. Margaret Morrison, "Models as Autonomous Agents," in *Models as Mediators: Perspectives on Natural and Social Science*, ed. Mary S. Morgan and Margaret Morrison (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 38–65; Marcel Boumans, "Built-in Justification," in *Models as Mediators: Perspectives on Natural and Social Science*, ed. Mary S. Morgan and Margaret Morrison (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 66–96.

42. Mary S. Morgan, "Learning from Models," in *Models as Mediators: Perspectives on Natural and Social Science*, ed. Mary S. Morgan and Margaret Morrison (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 347–388.

43. Morgan, *The World in the Model: How Economists Work and Think*, esp. ch. 10; Robert Sugden, "Mary S. Morgan's *The World in the Model*: How Economists Work and Think," *Erasmus Journal for Philosophy and Economics* 6, no. 1 (2013): 108–114; Verena Halsmayer, "Review of *The World in the Model*, by Mary S. Morgan," *Journal of the History of Economic Thought* 36, no. 4 (2014): 534–538.

44. Mary S. Morgan, "Models, Stories, and the Economic World," in *Fact and Fiction in Economics: Models, Realism, and Social Construction*, ed. Uskali Mäki (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002), 171–195; Mary S. Morgan, "Narrative and Models," in *The Routledge Handbook of Philosophy of Scientific Modeling*, ed. Tarja Knuuttila, Natalia Carrillo, and Rami Koskinen (London: Routledge, 2025), 367–381; Mary S. Morgan and Frank den Butter, *Empirical Models and Policy Making: Interaction and Institutions* (London: Routledge, 2000).

45. Mary S. Morgan, "Travelling Facts," in *How Well Do Facts Travel? The Dissemination of Reliable Knowledge*, ed. Mary S. Morgan and Peter Howlett (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), 3–42.

46. Morgan, *The World in the Model: How Economists Work and Think*, esp. ch. 10.

European form, was such a counter-theory; the Banking School position, as adapted by the Greek economists Stassinopoulos reconstructs, was a partial one.[47]

A *counter-narrative* is a rival story about what the polity adopting the regime will become, or about what kind of polity it already is. The same monetary theory can support more than one narrative. Trikoupis's civilisational story — Greece becomes a European modern state by adopting gold — is one narrative built on a roughly conventional 1880s European understanding of metallic standards; a nationalist-particularist narrative — Greece preserves a distinct path because European modernity does not fit Greek conditions — could have been built on the same theoretical materials and produced the opposite policy conclusion. A counter-narrative is therefore not derivable from a counter-theory and does not require one. It is a discursive object operating at the level of identity, aspiration, and historical destiny rather than at the level of mechanism.

Authority, finally, is the institutional capacity to be heard. A counter-theory, even a well-articulated one, may fail to count if the speaker lacks a parliamentary majority, factional discipline, expert standing, or the rhetorical positioning the chamber treats as serious. Conversely, a chamber may treat an argument as authoritative even when its theoretical and narrative content are thin, on the basis of who is speaking and from which institutional position.

The three are independent dimensions, and the critics' failure can be located on any combination of them. The reading developed in Sections V and VI is that the Greek critics had partial counter-theories (most clearly in the bimetallism that Section II flagged as available but parliamentarily absent), no counter-narrative at all, and asymmetric authority — with technical economists like Sotiropoulos commanding it on the loan question but not on the civilisational frame in which the loan question was posed. Reading these failures as a single "the critics lacked a counter-X" obscures the structural diagnosis the chapter pursues: the asymmetries differed in kind, and the model's decisive work was at the level of narrative and authority more than of theory.

This framework predicts that critics who attack the gold standard's technical apparatus while leaving its civilisational narrative intact will fail. The model's authority, in Morgan's sense, derives not just from its formal demonstration of stabilising and creditworthiness properties but from the story it tells about what Greece would become: a civilised, European, creditworthy nation. The critics could point to the arithmetic of debt service and the history of fiscal instability. They could not match the model's demonstration, or in Morgan's terms its Step 3, of a Greece transformed by monetary commitment.

3 Historical Context

Two institutional facts frame the parliamentary debates. First, the National Bank of Greece, established in 1841, held the exclusive privilege to issue banknotes while simultaneously function-

47. Stassinopoulos, "Economic Thought and Monetary Policy in Nineteenth-Century Greece."

ing as the government's fiscal agent, a dual role that would prove central to Greece's recurrent monetary crises.[48] Second, the 1875 "dedilomeni" principle established that governments required the declared confidence of a parliamentary majority to govern, inaugurating a two-party system dominated by Charilaos Trikoupis (the moderniser) and Theodoros Deligiannis (the conservative).[49] The paper accordingly refers to deputies aligned with Trikoupis as the *T-bloc* and to those aligned with Deligiannis as the *D-bloc*; deputies whose argumentative register stands apart from their voting bloc are designated *Independent* (Table 1 in Section V.3 carries the full coding). Monetary policy became a constant point of contestation between them.[5051]

Greece's 1867 accession to the Latin Monetary Union had already tied the drachma to a wider European monetary regime,[52] but the Union's convertibility discipline sat uneasily with

48. Olga Christodoulaki, "The Origins of Central Banking in Greece" (PhD diss., London School of Economics and Political Science, 2015).

49. Katerina Gardikas, "Parties and Politics in Greece, 1875–1885: Towards a Two-Party System" (PhD diss., University of London, 1988); Gunnar Hering, *Ta politika kommata stin Ellada, 1821–1936 [The Political Parties in Greece, 1821–1936]*, trans. Theodoros Paraskevopoulos, 2 vols., Greek translation of *Die politischen Parteien in Griechenland, 1821–1936*, Munich: Oldenbourg, 1992 (Athens: Morphotiko Idryma Ethnikis Trapezis (MIET), 2006); George B. Dertilis, *Istoria tou Ellinikou Kratous, 1830–1920 [History of the Greek State, 1830–1920]*, 2 vols. (Heraklion: Crete University Press, 2014).

50. Tricha, *Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politicos tou "Tis Ptaiei" kai tou "Dystychos Eptochevsamen" [Charilaos Trikoupis: The Politician of "Who's to Blame?" and "Regretfully, We Are Bankrupt"]*; Dimitris Pournaras, *Charilaos Trikoupis: i zoi kai to ergon tou [Charilaos Trikoupis: His Life and Work]* (Athens: Historike Bibliotheke, 1950).

51. Aliprantis observes that Tricha's biography demolishes the older characterisation of Trikoupis as the rising voice of a Greek bourgeois class — Trikoupis was instead, on her account, "the most representative offspring of the Greek political oligarchy" — and credits her with the most extensive treatment to date of the dedilomeni principle (Tricha (*Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politicos tou "Tis Ptaiei" kai tou "Dystychos Eptochevsamen" [Charilaos Trikoupis: The Politician of "Who's to Blame?" and "Regretfully, We Are Bankrupt"]*), pp. 250–254), of the broader contextual setting (pp. 223–234), of the post-1882 cabinets (pp. 317ff, 325–364), of the transition to the new system (pp. 433–448), and of the bankruptcy episode and its historiographical verdict (pp. 509–558, 558–566). He also flags her treatment of Deligiannis as "Manichean" and overly harsh, recommending Maroniti's more balanced reassessment as a corrective. In doing so, Aliprantis draws on Kostas Lappas, *Panepistimio kai foitites stin Ellada kata ton 19o aiona [University and Students in Greece during the 19th Century]* [in Greek] (Athens: Typois A. Papadima, 2004), Nikos Alivizatos, *To Syntagma kai oi echthroi tou sti Neoelliniki istoria, 1800–2010 [The Constitution and Its Enemies in Modern Greek History, 1800–2010]* [in Greek] (Athens: Patakis, 2011), Niki Maroniti, *Politiki exousia kai ethniko zitima stin Ellada, 1880–1910 [Political Power and the National Question in Greece, 1880–1910]* [in Greek] (Athens: Vivliorama, 2009), and Kostas Kostis, *Ta kakomaithimena paidia tis Istorias [The Spoilt Children of History]* [in Greek] (Athens: Polis, 2013) — all sources that challenge the bourgeois-class myth and the modernisation narrative surrounding Trikoupis; see also Aliprantis, "Review of Lydia Tricha, *Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politikos tou 'Tis Ptaiei?' kai tou 'Dystychos Eptochevsamen'*," 324–326.

52. The Latin Monetary Union was founded by treaty on 23 December 1865 between France, Belgium, Italy, and Switzerland, and entered into force on 1 August 1866; it was built on a bimetallic foundation with a gold-to-silver legal ratio of 15.5:1 inherited from the French franc. Greece was the only further state to join as a full member rather than as an associate. "1867" is used throughout this paper as the conventional shorthand for Greek LMU accession, but the process was multi-stage: the agreement was signed on 10 April 1867 under the Law on Monetary System; the formal accession law followed on 5 November 1868; the new system was scheduled to take effect on 1 January 1869. The Cretan Revolution of December 1868 forced the suspension of convertibility and postponed LMU implementation. Greece did not mint the new drachma at LMU parity until November 1882. Einaudi accordingly distinguishes Greek accession (1867) from effective membership, describing Greek membership as operationally constrained from 1869 onward and the Union's response as amounting to a "freezing" of Greek currency.Einaudi, *Money and Politics: European Monetary Unification and the International Gold Standard, 1865–1873* The period examined in this paper therefore covers both the delayed effective adoption (1882) and the subsequent push for full gold-standard convertibility (1884–85).Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949"; Stassinopoulos, "Economic Thought and Monetary Policy in Nineteenth-Century Greece"

the state's fiscal weakness.[53] "Fiscal weakness" here, as in the contemporary Greek and broader nineteenth-century usage Lazaretou and Levandis reconstruct, denotes a recurrent inability to balance ordinary revenues against ordinary expenditure without resort to short-term external borrowing, banknote issue against treasury bills, or revenue anticipations — a structural feature of the post-1830 Greek state's finances rather than a transient cyclical condition.[54] By the mid-1870s the problem had sharpened further: silver depreciation and the restriction of silver coinage were pushing the Union towards a de facto gold standard, so adherence promised access to European credit while also importing the distributional and political burdens of a monetary transformation designed elsewhere.[55] The immediate background to the gold standard debates was the forced circulation regime of 1877–1884, during which Greece minted its first drachma coins at LMU parity in November 1882, a fourteen-year gap between formal accession and effective adoption that the parliamentary debates of 1882–1885 were in part attempting to close. Convertibility was formally restored in early 1885.[56] During the Eastern Crisis accompanying the Russo-Turkish War of 1877–78, Greece mobilised its military (though it did not enter the conflict) and suspended convertibility, issuing inconvertible paper money to finance that mobilisation. The National Bank's notes circulated at a discount to gold, creating arbitrage opportunities that would surface repeatedly in parliamentary debate. Trikoupis's project to restore convertibility and adopt the gold standard was both an economic programme and a political response to what contemporaries treated as the indignity of forced circulation—a perception the parliamentary speeches examined below make visible.

4 The Parliamentary Debates, 1875–1885

4.1 Sources and Method

The reconstruction that follows draws on the digitised proceedings of the Hellenic Parliament covering 1875 to early 1886. The corpus comprises sixteen volumes (Hellenic Parliament reference numbers 100289 through 100304), holding 988 distinct session files in the per-session-ID layout used by the Library of the Hellenic Parliament's digitisation project. Each file corresponds to one chamber session and preserves the proceedings' Greek-language transcript, with session boundaries intact but printed-page markers from the original Ἐφημερὶς τῶν Συζητήσεων

53. Henry Parker Willis, *A History of the Latin Monetary Union* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1901); Georgios Alogoskoufis and Sophia Lazaretou, *I Drachmi: Nomismatika kathestota kai dimosionomikes diataraches sti neoteri Ellada [The Drachma: Monetary Regimes and Fiscal Disturbances in Modern Greece]*, IMOP (Athens: Athinaïki Oikonomiki Publications, 1997); Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949"; Pablo Martín-Aceña and Jaime Reis, eds., *Monetary Standards in the Periphery: Paper, Silver and Gold, 1854–1933* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2000).

54. Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949"; John A. Levandis, *The Greek Foreign Debt and the Great Powers, 1821–1898* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1944).

55. Morys, "The Gold Standard, Fiscal Dominance and Financial Supervision in Greece and South-East Europe, 1841–1939"; Alogoskoufis and Lazaretou, *I Drachmi: Nomismatika kathestota kai dimosionomikes diataraches sti neoteri Ellada [The Drachma: Monetary Regimes and Fiscal Disturbances in Modern Greece]*.

56. Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949."

τῆς Βουλῆς not preserved in the digitisation; this is why all parliamentary citations in the paper are given by session and dual date only.

The monetary question — coinage law, forced circulation, bank privileges, customs valuation, the 170 million franc loan, and after September 1885 the suspension and emergency legislation — was a recurring rather than continuous focus of parliamentary attention across this decade. A keyword sweep of the corpus for vocabulary that unambiguously marks substantive monetary-policy discussion — forced circulation, the National Bank, the 1867 monetary system and the *nomismatik-* root, bimetallism, monometallism, the Latin Monetary Union, and metallic-standard formulations — returns 409 of the 988 session files, or 41 per cent of the 1875–1885 chamber's recorded business.[57] The 988 sessions total approximately 11.7 million words, with a mean session length of 11,900 words, a median of 12,100 words, and a maximum of 38,200 words. At volume level, 255 of the 409 monetary-relevant sessions fall in the volumes covering the dense windows 1875–76, 1880, and 1883–85 (100290–100291, 100298, and 100300–100304), with the remaining 154 spread across the intervening volumes, consistent with the recurring-but-not-continuous reading. Within the 409 monetary-relevant sessions the median narrow-keyword density is 0.27 hits per 1,000 words, against 0.00 for the remaining sessions, supporting the reading that monetary debate was concentrated rather than diffuse. The question surfaced in concentrated bursts, typically tied to specific bills or budget debates, rather than as a permanent presence in the chamber's agenda. The episodes reconstructed below are the dense ones: December 1875 and December 1876 (the coinage and 1867-system debates), 1880 and early 1883 (the intermediate sequencing battles), November 1883 through December 1884 (the 170 million franc loan and the convertibility programme), and October through December 1885 (the post-suspension emergency).

Close reading was therefore not applied to the 988 files as an undifferentiated whole. Candidate sessions were selected where several signals overlapped: high density of the narrow monetary vocabulary just described; roll-call divisions on monetary bills, cross-referenced against the Paper-3 roll-call corpus; dates and measures flagged in the secondary literature on the National Bank, forced circulation, Trikoupis's cabinets, and the longer fiscal sequence;[58] and sessions adjacent in date to known bills under debate. The unit of close reading was thus the intersection of keyword salience, legislative event, historiographical signal, and bill-adjacent context, not the full run of 988 transcripts. The targeted Greek-language searches reported in Section V

57. Search performed against accent-stripped lower-case forms of the digitised text. The narrow keyword list is the union of: διμεταλλισμ, μονομεταλλισμ, ἀναγκαστικ + κυκλοφορ within 60 characters, νομισματ, ἐθνικ + τραπεζ within 30 characters, λατινικ + νομισματ within 25 characters, and μεταλλικ + νομισμ within 40 characters. A looser composite that also accepts sessions stacking at least two wide stems (drachma, gold, silver, loan, coinage, banknote) yields 703 of 988 (71 per cent), but this composite admits routine budget-line mentions of drachmas and is reported here only for sensitivity. Bimetallism alone returns just two sessions, providing independent confirmation of the absence claim developed in Section V.5.

58. Lazaretou, "Greece: From 1833 to 1949"; Tricha, *Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politicos tou "Tis Ptaiei" kai tou "Dystychos Eptochevsamen" [Charilaos Trikoupis: The Politician of "Who's to Blame?" and "Regretfully, We Are Bankrupt"]*; Levandis, *The Greek Foreign Debt and the Great Powers, 1821–1898*; Aliprantis, "Review of Lydia Tricha, *Charilaos Trikoupis: O Politikos tou 'Tis Ptaiei?' kai tou 'Dystychos Eptochevsamen'*."

cover the remaining files for claims whose evidential force depends on non-appearance outside the dense episodes.

The coding in Table 1 and Figure 1 should also be read as analytical coding rather than as a count of automatic labels. The *Argument type* and *Stance* columns, and the primary-register coding plotted in the figure, record the author's reading of each speaker's modal register across the bracketed sessions in which that speaker intervenes. Borderline cases were resolved by asking which register did most of the work across the relevant interventions, not by assigning every speech a separate label. Sotiropoulos is the useful example: his service as Finance Minister in 1875–76 makes a simple T-bloc/D-bloc or pro/anti coding misleading, but across the 1883–85 loan and convertibility debates his modal intervention is technical opposition from the Deligiannis side, which is why the table records him as D-bloc, technical, and against.

The transcripts themselves are chamber proceedings rather than thematic dossiers. A typical session opens with formalities, petitions, ministerial communications, and the fixing of the agenda, then moves through bills, committee reports, amendments, and occasional roll-call divisions; interpellations and local petitions interrupt the sequence when deputies use ordinary business to bring constituency grievances onto the floor. Monetary topics are accordingly interleaved with unrelated budget lines, administrative measures, military questions, and local claims, which is one reason the corpus is better read as bursts of monetary debate embedded in ordinary parliamentary business than as a continuous monetary archive. The digitisation preserves polytonic Greek with uneven OCR conditions: headings and names are usually legible, while accents, line breaks, hyphenation, and some numerals require manual checking against context.

The method is close reading of these dense episodes, supplemented by targeted Greek-language search across the full corpus for claims that depend on absence rather than presence. The bimetallism non-uptake claim of Section V.5 is the worked example: the corpus was swept for parliamentary advocacy of bimetallism, a silver standard, or any non-gold metallic framework as a positive Greek programme, and the search returned no positive-programme hit (only descriptive, polemical, anti-bimetallist, and contract-clause uses of the relevant vocabulary). The audit's classification scheme and known coverage limitations are reported in the corresponding footnote in Section V.5. No automated topic modelling or quantitative discourse analysis is performed in this paper; both are noted as natural extensions of the method in Section VII.[59]

This methodological choice has a defensible rationale and a real cost. The benefit is that the four observations the analytical sections develop are anchored in close attention to the chamber's actual exchanges — their rhetorical structure, their faction-by-register patterning, and the moments at which speakers either converge or talk past each other — in a way that automated methods would not capture without considerable additional calibration. The cost is that the absence claims (Section V.5 most prominently) rest on the calibration of the targeted searches

59. Lino Wehrheim, "Economic History Goes Digital: Topic Modeling the *Journal of Economic History*," *Cliometrica* 13, no. 1 (2019): 83–125.

rather than on a corpus-wide statistical test. The footnoted audit is the response to that cost; topic modelling at corpus scale would be a stronger one and is flagged as future work.

4.2 Coinage, Arbitrage, and Constitutional Objections, 1875–1878

The parliamentary debates over gold standard adoption begin not with gold but with coinage, arbitrage, and the unfinished implementation of the 1867 monetary law. In December 1875 ministers acknowledged that new bronze coins had been released before the new monetary system itself had come into force, creating a speculative opportunity: holders of the new bronze pieces stood to gain when the new unit was finally activated.[60]

The problem was broader than small change. It joined together the premature circulation of new bronze coins, the planned activation of the 1867 monetary system, and the legal status of foreign and subsidiary coin in everyday transactions. In December 1876 Parliament returned to the issue through the ratification of the March decree excluding foreign silver coins from public treasuries and through renewed debate over the "new monetary system" itself.[61] What matters analytically is that early Greek monetary politics were already about sequencing, legal authority, and the distribution of gains and losses from monetary change.

The government's response was therefore not a single clean reform but a sequence of decrees, postponements, and partial adjustments. That sequencing, rather than gold as such, provoked the first sustained parliamentary objections.

The proceedings also show what the deputies did *not* do. The problem they were confronting – multiple coinages circulating at legally defined but politically contested values – was precisely the sort of problem to which bimetallism might have supplied a principled answer. Yet the parliamentary record does not show a positive Greek bimetallist programme. Deligeorgis explicitly attacked the "two-unit" character of the 1867 system, and Zochios later used mixed gold-silver payment rules as a reductio against official equivalence, but no deputy defended bimetallism as Greece's preferred monetary order. Bimetallist vocabulary does appear in the proceedings, but only in descriptive or polemical registers — not as a sustained parliamentary programme for a Greek silver or bimetallic standard. The significance of this silence will be taken up in Section V.

Epameinondas Deligeorgis was a former prime minister (his last government had ended in February 1874) and leader of the National Committee party (Ἐθνικὸ Κομιτάτο). He was also one of several senior opposition voices in the fragmented parliamentary landscape of 1875, when Koumoundouros held only a plurality and no single figure commanded the opposition.[62]

60. Sotiropoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 58, 5/17 December 1875.

61. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 47, 11/23 December 1876 (third reading of the decree excluding foreign silver coins from public treasuries, and the government's constitutional defence of the decree route).

62. The National Committee was a real party founded by Deligeorgis in the mid-1860s and active through his death in 1879; it appears in electoral records and in the labelling of his successive governments. The parliamentary transcripts of the December 1875 sessions examined here, however, attach no party label to any deputy. Deligeorgis appears under his name label in the same label-free form as every other non-ministerial speaker, while ministers

In the December 1875 debates over postponing the 1867 law's implementation, Deligeorgis first rose to challenge the government's authority. His argument was constitutional: monetary change required legislation, not a mere parliamentary decision or executive decree. "I say therefore that a law cannot be suspended by a simple decision of Parliament... a decree is something else, it is an act of the executive power... it requires a law".[63]

Deligeorgis's objection was not mere proceduralism. He was articulating a deeper concern: that executive power over monetary policy, unchecked by legislation, could be abused to redistribute wealth without consent. The decree, he noted, would in effect "suspend" an existing monetary law without parliamentary authorisation. In a constitutional order that had only recently established parliamentary supremacy through the dedilomeni principle, this mattered.

The distributional argument was voiced most sharply by Gerasimos Zochios (T-bloc MP for Mesi, Corfu),[64] who treated the transition as a mechanism for transferring gains to speculators and losses to those dependent on small transactions. In the December 1875 debates critics warned that the premature circulation of new bronze coins had already created a speculative premium; in December 1876 Zochios pushed the logic further by demanding that salaries and taxes be handled "three-quarters in gold and one-quarter in silver" if ministers truly believed the official equivalence between the two metals.[65]

A third line of objection came from provincial deputies, especially those speaking from the Ionian Islands (incorporated only a decade earlier, in 1864), who articulated what European monetary theory did not anticipate: the geography of monetary integration. Cross-border trade, local tax collection, and petty exchange still depended on coin types whose acceptance Athens could alter by decree.[66] Vellanitis (Ionian Islands) made the point concretely: cross-border trade with Epirus ran in Mexican and German talers, and two coinage decrees in 1875–76 had disrupted that trade by decree rather than by legislation.[67] The metropolitan perspective that informed European monetary theory, written from the standpoint of capital cities and financial centres, had little reason to develop these arguments. They emerged from the experience of a peripheral parliament grappling with the uneven costs of monetary transformation.

Nor were these critics antimodern traditionalists. Deligeorgis attacked the 1867/LMU order

carry portfolio tags with their names and portfolio designations. The party's existence and his leadership of it are well attested outside the chamber; the transcripts' convention is simply not to record factional affiliation on the floor.

63. Deligeorgis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 58, 5/17 December 1875.

64. The name appears as "Thrasyvoulos Zohios" in some early secondary sources; the correct figure is Gerasimos Zochios, former Minister of Naval Affairs and T-bloc representative for Mesi.

65. Zochios, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 47, 11/23 December 1876. The polemical character of the proposal is confirmed by Zochios's own retrospective gloss after his withdrawal of the motion at the close of the session: ('I made this proposal in order to show that the Government did not bring the French currency into Greece, because it cast out the gold coin and is not in a position to bring it; it brought only the debased coin'). The President's record at the same juncture reads: ('Mr Zochios withdraws his proposal').

66. Alogoskoufis and Lazaretou, *I Drachmi: Nomismatika kathestota kai dimosionomikes diataraches sti neoteri Ellada [The Drachma: Monetary Regimes and Fiscal Disturbances in Modern Greece]*.

67. Vellanitis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 47, 11/23 December 1876.

from the opposite direction.[68]

In the debate of 11/23 December 1875 he argued that the "two-unit" system had been condemned by international experience and that a system with gold as the unit would serve Greek commerce better, particularly given trade with England in gold pounds.[69] His objection was therefore not to monetary modernisation as such, but to what he saw as the wrong and constitutionally mishandled route into it. Mpoumpoulis added a politically potent objection: conversion into the new unit would function like a tax because bread, oil, wages, and everyday prices would be rounded upwards in practice.[70]

The government's response, delivered by Sotirios Sotiropoulos (then serving as Finance Minister in the Koumoundouros government, despite his later alignment with what became the Deligiannis opposition) and by Trikoupis in subsequent debates, combined precedent with necessity.[71] Previous governments, Sotiropoulos noted, had issued similar decrees during crises. Economic necessity, namely the arbitrage draining silver reserves, justified executive action. But the defence was more than technical. Trikoupis framed the bronze coin reform as a step towards a larger goal: monetary modernisation that would bring Greece into line with the other civilised states.

Already in 1875–1876, we can see the pattern that would structure the next decade. Parliamentary critics from different factions mixed constitutional, distributional, regional, and rival monetary arguments in ways European theory did not anticipate. The government defended its policies not just on technical grounds but through a civilisational narrative: Greece must modernise its monetary system to join Europe.[72] The critics offered alternatives in fragments: postponement, legal ratification, different sequencing, and in Deligeorgis's case a more explicitly gold-based standard. They did not offer a counter-model with comparable authority.

Parliament returned to the bronze question again in June 1877, when deputies debated further issues of bronze coinage, showing that the controversy had not been exhausted by the December sessions.[73]

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68. Deligeorgis died on 14 May 1879 and thus appears only in the 1875–1878 parliamentary debates examined here. His arguments nevertheless cast a long shadow over subsequent debate.

69. Deligeorgis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 61, 11/23 December 1875. On gold-first: ('the only advantageous system is that based on a single metallic unit, and that unit must be gold'). On the dual-unit condemnation: ('the system of 1867, which has as its monetary unit both silver and gold, while today the double monetary unit has been wholly condemned').

70. Mpoumpoulis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 59, 8/20 December 1875: ('...the worker will go to the grocer to buy ten-lepta worth of bread, wine, and olives, and while he gives a new ten-lepton piece he will not receive eleven lepta in olives, because these fractions are lost in this small transaction... thus the daily wage increases 12 percent').

71. Sotiropoulos's ministerial role here (Finance Minister under Koumoundouros, 1875–76) should not obscure the fact that he became, over the 1875–1885 period, a D-bloc figure: by the 1882–1885 debates he appears as the most technically sophisticated voice in what had crystallised after 1883 as the Deligiannis opposition. The shifting role, government minister at one moment and opposition economist at another, reflects the fluid coalitional politics of the dedilomeni era, in which the two-party structure of the later 1880s was still forming.

72. For a historiographical challenge to the "modernisation" framing of Greek nineteenth-century politics, see Kostis, *Ta kakomaithimena paidia tis Istorias [The Spoilt Children of History]*.

73. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 35, 30 June/12 July 1877.

Nor did the controversy end with the early coinage crisis. Between 1880 and early 1883 Parliament returned repeatedly to monetary questions: customs conversion, forced circulation, bank privileges, and minor coinage bills. These debates reveal an escalating dynamic: government majorities still won, but by narrower margins and against increasingly specific technical objections.[74]

The sequencing argument was the sharpest of these objections. Critics insisted that the state was attempting to impose the "new drachma" as the unit of account in customs valuation and public contracts before the monetary system had been stabilised and before adequate coin supply existed. Papamichalopoulos's amendment to exempt basic necessities from customs conversion was defeated by 88 votes to 54, a government majority of 34.[75] When the principle of the forced-circulation bill came to a vote, the government prevailed by only 107 votes to 85, a margin of 22.[76] Two and a quarter years later, on the amendment to article 11 of the 1867 monetary-system law — the bill that extended forced circulation to the new copper coinage — Filaretos's motion to defer first reading was rejected 96 to 75 (171 voting, a government margin of 21), and the principle then carried by 94 votes to 71 (165 voting, a margin of 23).[77] The votes were won, but the arithmetic recorded a contested base of consent.

The substantive warnings were equally precise. Opposition speakers argued that further issues of inconvertible paper, weak public credit, and loans extracted through additional concessions would burden consumers and bring the language of bankruptcy into fiscal debate.[78] This was not mere rhetoric: it articulated, in the idiom available to the deputies, the mechanism through which monetary expedients could become fiscal crisis. Rontiris pressed the distributional point: conversion into the new drachma unit would cut real wages because everyday prices (coffee, bread, wages, and petty consumption) would be rounded upwards rather than downwards in practice, producing an implicit redistribution from wage-earners to traders.[79]

Two things make these intermediate battles analytically significant. First, they demonstrate that the 1882–1885 gold standard showdown was not an episode of sudden monetary politics but the culmination of a debate that had been running, and sharpening, for seven years. The critics had refined their arguments through repeated parliamentary encounters; they were not improvising when the 170 million franc loan came before the chamber. Second, the sequencing argument made in 1880 is the same argument, in embryonic form, that the paper identifies as the core of the precondition critique — and as the sketch of a "not now" alternative justification that no faction ever assembled into a programme: Greece was trying to adopt the institutional forms

74. See, for example, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 112, 15/27 April 1880; Session 51, 19/31 December 1880; Session 91, 11/23 March 1881; and Session 44, 25 January/6 February 1883.

75. Papamichalopoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 112, 15/27 April 1880.

76. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 51, 19/31 December 1880. The recorded division was 192 total, 107 for, 85 against, accepted.

77. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 44, 25 January/6 February 1883.

78. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 51, 19/31 December 1880 (on opposition arguments during the forced-circulation debates).

79. Rontiris, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 59, 8/20 December 1875.

of a gold standard (defined units, customs denominated in new drachma, forced circulation at parity) before the fiscal and monetary preconditions for those forms to function had been established. The critics were articulating the gap between model and precondition. Trikoupis, for his part, later defended the pace of reform by arguing that restored metallic stability and stronger public credit were necessary to open foreign markets and make Greece a financial centre in the East.[80]

4.3 The 170 Million Franc Loan and the Promise of Convertibility, 1882–1885

The early coinage crisis established the terms of debate. The 1882–1885 period saw those debates escalate as Trikoupis pursued his signature monetary project: the restoration of convertibility and the adoption of the gold standard.[81]

Trikoupis's civilisational framing reached its fullest expression in the parliamentary debates of 1883–1884. Gold, he argued, was not merely a monetary standard but a prerequisite for civilised status. In a speech whose rhetorical power drew on decades of Greek engagement with European modernity, he promised that the programme would bring Greece "into line with the other civilised states" and make it the "Stock Exchange of the East" through the lifting of forced circulation.[82]

This framing performed what we might call "categorical displacement". Distributional objections about who would bear the costs of adjustment, regional equity, and the burden of foreign debt were not refuted but reframed. They became signs of insufficient national ambition, misplaced pessimism, and failure to understand the necessity of European alignment.

Critics had contested this civilisational rhetoric from the start. In the first round of monetary debates, Rontiris objected that the "true science" of the question had been ignored when ministers reduced monetary change to exchange-rate convenience, while Zochios tested official equivalence between the metals by demanding mixed gold-silver payments for salaries and taxes.[83] Deligeorgis likewise warned against treating international monetary practice as automatically transferable to Greek constitutional and commercial conditions, drawing on international evidence selectively to condemn the dual-unit structure of the 1867 law rather than to endorse the government's implementation route. The target of his criticism was not gold per se. As his December 1875 speeches make clear, Deligeorgis rejected the 1867 dual-unit order

80. Trikoupis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 8, 14/26 November 1883; Session 8, 15/27 November 1884 (Deligiannis's quotation of Trikoupis's 24 November/6 December and 22 December 1883 speeches). Deligiannis's hostile reconstruction is especially useful because it preserves the technical sequence Trikoupis had offered: lift forced circulation first, acquire the credit enjoyed by states not under forced circulation, then issue the loan from a stronger position in foreign markets.

81. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 8, 14/26 November 1883.

82. Trikoupis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 8, 14/26 November 1883. In the same passage Trikoupis supplied the technical mechanism behind the phrase: forced circulation was driving capital away from Greece, while money whose value was recognised by the general market of the world would attract capital and give the Greek market its natural position.

83. Rontiris, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 59, 8/20 December 1875; Zochios, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 47, 11/23 December 1876.

and argued for a more direct move to a gold-unit standard.

The 170 million franc loan became the focal point of contestation.[84] Trikoupis had promised Parliament on 24 November/6 December 1883 that he would issue the loan only after convertibility had been restored.[85] Yet the bonds were issued within months on deeply discounted terms: Sotiropoulos described a public issue price of 346.50 per 500-franc bond and an option price of 342.50 once *jouissance* and related gains were considered.[86] The official Minority Report of the Budget Committee characterised the terms as "outright degrading" (αὐτόχρημα ἐξευτελιστικοὶ) and a stain on the country's credit.[87] Sotiropoulos, by now a leading voice of the Deligiannis opposition and the most technically sophisticated economist among the loan's critics, treated the terms as usurious, arguing that the discounts, commissions, and *jouissance* transferred extraordinary gains to the bankers.[88] Zygomalas pressed the government to produce the foreign correspondence surrounding the loan, including communications from Greek authorities in Austria, Germany, and Britain, precisely because the parliamentary record of the loan's external reception remained contested.[89]

The critics' technical objections were directionally accurate in a predictive sense. The loan was issued on unfavourable terms. Debt service would strain the treasury. Convertibility was fragile. Critics warned that, without fiscal balance and credible public finances, forced circulation and metallic stability could not be managed on favourable terms; the suspension of September 1885 and the bankruptcy of December 1893 later made those warnings empirically visible.[90][91]

84. Levandis, *The Greek Foreign Debt and the Great Powers, 1821–1898*.

85. Trikoupis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 16, 24 November/6 December 1883; Deligiannis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 8, 15/27 November 1884; Sotiropoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 15, 27 November/9 December 1884.

86. Sotiropoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 15, 27 November/9 December 1884. The 346.50 issue price appears in three OCR variants in the digitised transcript. Sotiropoulos presents the 342.50 option price as his own analytical recasting of the effective price after adjustments rather than as a government-stated number. The technical mechanism behind the recasting: bondholders ('would also receive the interest of one half-year by virtue of jouissance'). The French term *jouissance* appears in Latin script in the original Greek transcript (sometimes rendered *juissance* in OCR), used as a technical loanword without translation.

87. Minority Report of the Budget Committee, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 28, 10/22 December 1883. The fuller clause is striking: ('that the terms thereof are outright degrading for the State, inasmuch as through them the credit is stigmatised and the economic future of our country is bound'). The Minority Report's characterisation is therefore not merely rhetorical: it specifies the credit-stigma and future-binding mechanisms that the paper attributes to the loan's critics analytically.

88. Sotiropoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 15, 27 November/9 December 1884. Sotiropoulos uses the simple plural ('bankers') rather than the more institutional ('banking group'), but the substantive claim about extraordinary gains is anchored in his speech: ('we are able to give them similar gains'), and he further specifies ('how much they are gaining from this enterprise').

89. Zygomalas, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 21, 5/17 December 1884.

90. Maria Christina Chatziioannou, *Greek Sovereign Debt and Loans in 19th-Century Public Discourse* (London: Routledge, 2019).

91. Sotiropoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 15, 27 November/9 December 1884; Zinopoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 46, 4/16 December 1885. The Zinopoulos warning requires care in its restatement. Strictly read, his argument concerns the loan rather than convertibility directly: ('if we do not have a balanced budget, I greatly fear that this our attempt — for we must call it an attempt — concerning a loan may possibly fail'). The transitivity to convertibility runs through the loan as instrument: Zinopoulos opens by treating the loan as ('inseparably connected') to the forced-circulation bill, and identifies the loan as the instrument for reducing ('the

But the government had something the critics lacked: a model with narrative authority. The gold standard model did not just promise stabilising properties; it told a story about what Greece would become. Civilised. European. Creditworthy. The critics could quantify the loan's discount, trace the commissions and *jouissance* gains, and project the burden of debt service on the treasury. They could not demonstrate, as Trikoupis's project could, a transformed Greece on the far side of convertibility. That asymmetry between technical precision on the critics' side and model-based demonstration on the government's would define the remainder of the debate.

4.4 Collapse and Vindication, September–December 1885

The predictive vindication of the critics came quickly. Fiscal pressures had been accumulating since late 1884, with debt service, forced circulation, and fragile convertibility already straining the treasury the critics had warned about. Even before the Eastern Rumelian crisis, Valassopoulos had described a state carrying roughly 654 million drachmas of debt, facing an 18–19 million drachma deficit, and absorbing the effects of withdrawing 55 million drachmas of banknotes from circulation.[92] In September 1885, Bulgaria's annexation of Eastern Rumelia forced Greece to mobilise its army, sharply compounding those pre-existing pressures rather than creating them anew. The fiscal consequences were immediate: deputies described tens of millions of drachmas in extraordinary resources, renewed borrowing on forced circulation, and expensive foreign exchange purchases for army and navy materiel. The October emergency legislation made the mechanism visible, pairing a proposed 30 million drachma patriotic loan with renewed forced circulation and bank contracts that expanded the circulation of banknotes.[93]

Within months of restoration, Greece suspended convertibility in September 1885. Speakers and petitioners described banknotes trading below metallic parity: Arta merchants reported a 20% depreciation of Epirus-Thessaly notes elsewhere, while Balsamakis warned that a paper

terrible consequences of forced circulation'). Zinopoulos's balanced-budget precondition is therefore attached most immediately to the loan, but the loan was itself the instrument of continued forced-circulation removal after the September 1885 suspension; the precondition argument compresses defensibly into a precondition for the convertibility programme as a whole.

92. Valassopoulos, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 53, 16/28 July 1885.

93. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 12, 24 October/5 November 1885. The bill was introduced as a ('patriotic loan of 30,000,000 drachmas') and stated that ('forced circulation is again established'). The same session records the banking mechanics around the National Bank and the Bank of Epirus-Thessaly, including Deligiannis's confirmation of the 800,000, two-million, and twelve-million figures under debate. Two retrospective parliamentary accountings quantify the cumulative damage. Trikoupis's own self-accounting in Session 25, 27 October/8 November 1886, reported banknote circulation rising from 109,500,000 to 128,000,000 drachmas with authorisation extended to 144,000,000; floating debt rising from 66,400,000 to 200,022,500 drachmas since early 1885; and extraordinary military expenditure of approximately 55,000,000 drachmas for army service plus 15,000,000 or more for naval service, totalling 70–72 million. Deligiannis's forensic calculation in Session 38, 19/31 March 1887, gave the year-by-year mobilisation cost as 25,221,307.83 drachmas (1885) plus 13,291,279.91 drachmas (1886), totalling 38,512,587.74 drachmas, with approximately 9 million additional drachmas in unpaid European procurement debts incurred while ('gold currency had been overvalued to the maximum degree'). The Deligiannis breakdown is significant beyond the headline number: it shows that mobilisation costs continued to compound into 1886, supporting the reading that the September 1885 collapse was not a discrete shock the system survived but the visible threshold of an extended fiscal cascade.

discount could move from 10% toward 30 or 50%.[94] In Arta, merchants warned they might close their shops and cease trading; Karapanos told Parliament that all transactions there risked coming to a halt. By December, the disappearance of metallic coin from everyday exchange had become explicit enough for the government to seek authorisation for 18 million drachmas in small-denomination banknotes.[95] The fractional paper money produced exactly the legal ambiguity Trikoupis identified in October 1885, with Balsamakis warning that indeterminate rules would generate "innumerable lawsuits" over paper-money obligations.[96]

The parliamentary reckoning was sharp. The same deputies who had warned about debt sustainability, forced circulation, regional paper-money effects, and the fragility of convertibility could now point to precisely those mechanisms in operation. Dimitrakakis, for example, returned in December 1885 to the 170 million loan, the treatment of coupons and interest, the damage done to public credit, and the earlier promise that money would flow back once forced circulation was lifted.[97] The same chamber that had authorised the gold-standard project was now managing its collapse.

But even predictive accuracy did not translate into political success. The critics had identified the near-term failure mechanisms of loan burden, forced circulation, and fragile convertibility. That is not the same as proving that their monetary theory was superior in general. They had not assembled a counter-model that could demonstrate an alternative policy course. Their arguments about regional equity and constitutional propriety remained precisely that: arguments, not instruments of demonstration. In Morgan's terms, they were contesting the model at Step 4 (narrative contestation) while Trikoupis had controlled Steps 1–3 (model construction, interrogation, demonstration) from the outset.

The collapse also revealed something else: the gold standard experiment continued to shape the political terrain even in failure. By October 1885, Trikoupis himself was attacking the system he had built, not because he had abandoned the aspiration to monetary credibility, but because the emergency had forced choices that the framework could not accommodate. Parliament was left managing the wreckage of the experiment rather than debating a fully articulated alternative.

94. Arta merchants' telegram and Karapanos confirmation, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 20, 4/16 November 1885. The merchants' telegram was read into the record by the President of the Chamber: ('Epirus-Thessaly banknotes have been depreciated here; elsewhere by 20 percent'). Balsamakis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 12, 24 October/5 November 1885: ('they have depreciation of ten percent…if depreciation in the meantime should reach thirty or fifty percent').

95. Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 54, 12/24 December 1885: ('18 million in fractional banknotes'); ('forced circulation drove metallic coins out of transactions').

96. Both citations are in Session 12, 24 October/5 November 1885: Trikoupis on the obscurity of the forced-circulation clause, and Balsamakis on the prospect of innumerable lawsuits.

97. Dimitrakakis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 49, 7/19 December 1885. See also the retrospective parliamentary accounting in Session 63, 30 March/11 April 1886, which tallied the mobilisation's fiscal consequences: the calling-up of five age cohorts, the return to forced circulation, army supply failures, and extraordinary foreign-exchange costs for military procurement.

5 Observations and Analytical Discussion

Four observations emerge from the parliamentary record. They are extracted here as a set because, taken together, they carry implications for Morgan's framework that the evidence sections can only suggest. The purpose of this section is to step back from the parliamentary voices and speak as analyst: to ask not what was said but what the pattern of saying and losing reveals about how models function in political institutions.

The four observations that follow rest on an analytical separation that the paper has so far left implicit. Two claims have been running together in the paper's framing, and they carry different evidentiary loads.

The first is that the preconditions for sustainable gold adoption did not hold in Greece in 1882–1885: fiscal weakness, the National Bank's dual role as note-issuer and treasury agent, regional fragmentation of monetary circulation, the constitutional constraints on executive monetary action, and the unfinished implementation of the 1867/LMU framework. This claim is observable in real time and is fully supported by the 1875–1885 parliamentary archive reconstructed in Section IV. The critics articulated these preconditions, register by register, throughout the decade.

The second is that policy failure followed from precondition absence. This is the predictive-vindication claim, and it carries temporal layers the 1875–1885 cutoff does not all support equally. The September 1885 suspension is partial vindication, demonstrating the immediate operational consequences (loan burden, regional paper-money effects, fragility of convertibility under shock) but open to the reading that the September 1885 mobilisation following Bulgaria's annexation of Eastern Rumelia, rather than structural unworkability, brought the system down. The December 1893 bankruptcy and the 1898 turn to international financial control would carry the structural reading more fully, but those lie beyond the reconstructed period and are flagged in Section VII as future work.

The precondition argument therefore rests primarily on the first claim. The contribution is not that the critics predicted outcomes and were vindicated, which would lean on temporal extension this paper has not undertaken, but that they articulated, in real time, the preconditions the model had shed at its site of construction, and that the model's authority depended on rendering those preconditions invisible at the point of adoption. This is a tighter fit to Morgan's framework than the predictive reading: a model travels by shedding caveats, and what looked like fragmented local objections in the Greek chamber were the missing preconditions made invisible at the moment of travel. The four observations that follow are best read as claims about epistemic structure rather than as claims about prediction; the partial vindication of 1885 supports them but does not exhaust them.

5.1 Observation 1: Critics were predictively accurate but institutionally powerless

The first observation is the accuracy-without-authority paradox. Across three distinct episodes and a decade of debate, parliamentary critics of the gold standard project identified the structural problems of Greek monetary policy with striking precision. Sotiropoulos treated the 1883 loan terms as usurious once discount, commission, and *jouissance* were considered. Zinopoulos warned that convertibility without a balanced budget would fail. Zygomalas pressed for foreign correspondence on the loan's reception. Valassopoulos, on the eve of the crisis, named the headline magnitudes — roughly 654 million drachmas of debt, an 18–19 million drachma deficit, and 55 million in withdrawn banknotes — before the Eastern Rumelian shock arrived. Rontiris and Mpoumpoulis identified distributional losses from monetary conversion, while in the late-1885 sessions the Arta merchants and Karapanos traced regional paper-money depreciation, Balsamakis warned of escalating discount and "innumerable lawsuits" over paper obligations, and Dimitrakakis returned to the 170 million loan, the coupons and interest, the damage to public credit, and the broken promise that money would flow back once forced circulation was lifted. The September 1885 suspension supplied immediate operational confirmation of several of these warnings: convertibility was suspended within months of restoration, and the loan terms continued to strain the treasury. The deeper fiscal-fragility reading that the 1893 bankruptcy and the 1898 turn to international financial control would later support lies beyond this paper's reconstruction and is not relied on here. What the immediate 1885 confirmation supports, the precondition reading interprets: each warning named a scope condition the model had shed at travel.

And yet, in the decisive divisions reconstructed here, the critics lost.

In Morgan's terms, this outcome reflects the asymmetry between *model autonomy* and *local knowledge*. The gold standard model had been constructed from heterogeneous materials over decades and in settings far removed from Athens. It had its own internal logic, its own demonstration capacity: run the model, and it showed that gold adherence produced creditworthiness, which produced capital inflows, which produced development. The critics' objections were locally grounded and predictively accurate, but they lacked this autonomous demonstrative form. To say that Greece's fiscal position made convertibility fragile was not to demonstrate an alternative future; it was to identify a caveat. Caveats, in Morgan's framework, are absorbed or discarded as models travel. They do not stop a model. Only a counter-model can stop a model.

5.2 Observation 2: The government's defence bundled technical claims with civilisational narrative

The second observation is that the government's parliamentary defence acquired authority by bundling technical claims with civilisational narrative. Trikoupis did not answer the critics primarily by building a rival calculation of the loan's true cost, the budget's sustainability, or the fragility of convertibility. But his defence did rest on a technical proposition: restored convertibility would strengthen public credit, lower the cost of borrowing, stabilise circulation, and attract capital into Greece.[98]

This is what the paper calls "categorical displacement." The operative move was not simply to show that the critics were wrong about the numbers, but to relocate their objections into a different evaluative frame where they became evidence of character rather than technical argument. A deputy who warned about debt sustainability could be treated not as offering a rival account of sequencing, but as failing to understand what it meant to be a European nation. The civilisational narrative performed this displacement because the critics' constitutional, distributional, regional, and technical fragments were not bundled into an authoritative alternative.

Morgan's work on narrative embedding illuminates the mechanism precisely. She shows that models gain authority not only through formal demonstration but through the stories they enable: stories about what the world *could* be if the model's prescriptions were followed.[99] The gold standard model for Greece told a specific story: a Greece that adopts convertibility becomes creditworthy, comes into line with the other civilised states, secures access to European capital, and becomes a financial centre in the East. This story was immensely powerful in the political culture of a newly independent state still defining its relationship to European modernity.[100] The critics could point to what Greece *was* (fiscally fragile, regionally divided, constitutionally constrained), and in places they identified real technical mechanisms. They could not convert those claims into a counter-narrative of what Greece could *become* through a different sequence, nor into the counter-theory that would have given such a narrative its causal backing.

Morrison's challenge suggests that the Greek case should not be framed as narrative government against technical critics. Trikoupis's defenders also offered technical arguments: restored convertibility would strengthen public credit, reduce the costs of foreign borrowing, stabilise monetary circulation, attract mobile capital, and make Greece a financial centre in the East. The critics' failure was therefore not only narrative. It was also epistemic. They identified preconditions that were missing, but they did not produce a coherent counter-theory of how a peripheral state should sequence fiscal repair, banknote management, foreign borrowing, and metallic convertibility.

Figure 1 maps the primary argumentative register of each speaker by faction. Most critics, economist or not, sit in the technical/economic half; Deligeorgis is the constitutional exception, and only Trikoupis's primary register is political/narrative. The asymmetry visible here is not narrative-versus-technical, which Morrison's challenge has already ruled out, but asymmetric

98. The clearest evidence is Deligiannis's hostile quotation of Trikoupis's earlier defence of the loan: Trikoupis had argued that, once forced circulation was lifted, Greece would acquire the credit of states not under forced circulation and could issue the loan on the basis of the improved situation produced by that lifting. Deligiannis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 8, 15/27 November 1884, quoting Trikoupis's speeches of 24 November/6 December and 22 December 1883.

99. Morgan, *The World in the Model: How Economists Work and Think*, esp. ch. 10.

100. Kostas Kostis, *History's Spoiled Children: The Formation of the Modern Greek State* (Budapest: CEU Press, 2018).

bundling: the critics offered technical or constitutional claims alone, while Trikoupis offered technical claims bundled with civilisational narrative. The bundling is observable at the paragraph level. In Trikoupis's Session 8 peroration of November 1883 (see footnote 1 above for verbatim Greek), the civilisational claim (*into the parallel of the other civilised States*, *Stock Exchange of the East*) and the technical mechanism (*capital comes only where the currency has the value recognised by the general market of the world*, *the lifting of forced circulation will open an asylum to capital*) appear in a single uninterrupted twelve-line rhetorical unit. The bundling is not the analyst's reconstruction but the speaker's compositional choice.

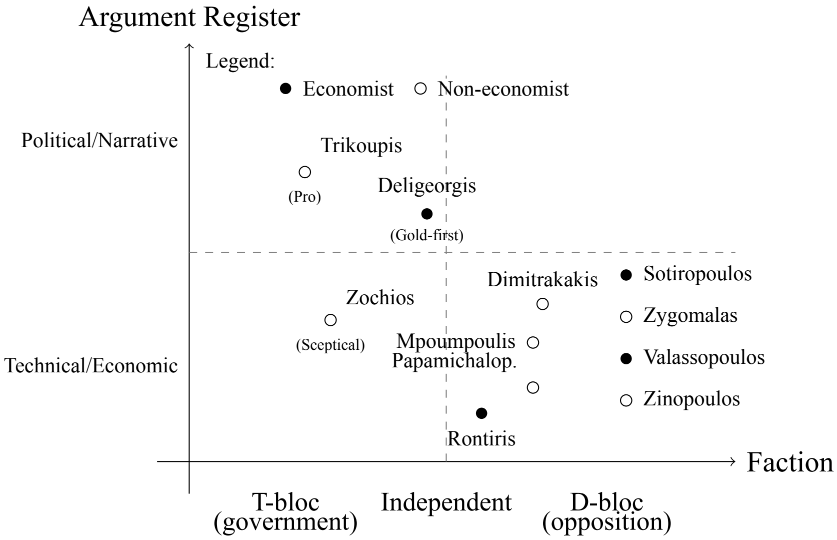

Figure 1: Faction by argument register (primary coding). Critics cluster mostly in technical/economic engagement, with Deligeorgis as the constitutional exception; only Trikoupis's primary register is political/narrative. The figure shows surface clustering, not the technical-versus-civilisational *bundling* the running text identifies as the operative asymmetry.

5.3 Observation 3: Critics' arguments were fragmented across incommensurable registers

The third observation is the structural fragmentation of parliamentary criticism across factions. Table 1 maps the key figures in the debates along two axes: their primary type of objection (constitutional-procedural, distributional, regional, technical-economic, or gradualist) and their stance towards the gold standard project. The distribution reveals that critics did not coalesce around a single explicit counter-programme in the proceedings examined here.

What Table 1 shows is that the critics' objections operated in at least five distinct registers (constitutional, distributional, regional, technical-economic, and gradualist) that were not synthesised into a shared programme. The fragmentation operated in parallel on two levels. Analytically, as the table shows, the registers of criticism did not converge. Procedurally, the proceedings themselves do not record party affiliations on the floor: deputies appear by surname alone, and factional coordination, where it existed, is visible only in roll-call patterns

Table 1: Key parliamentarians in the Greek gold standard debates, 1875–1885

Name	Faction	Argument type	Stance	Econ.?
Trikoupis	T-bloc	Civilisational	Pro	No
Sotiropoulos	D-bloc	Technical	Against†	Yes
Deligiannis	D-bloc	Gradualist	Against	No
Deligeorgis	Independent	Constitutional	Gold-first	Yes
Zochios	T-bloc	Distributional	Sceptical	No
Papamichalopoulos	D-bloc	Regional-consumer	Against	No
Vellanitis	Independent	Regional-commercial	Sceptical	No
Mpoumpoulis	D-bloc	Distributional	Against	No
Zygomalas	D-bloc	Technical	Against	No
Zinopoulos	D-bloc	Technical	Against	No
Valassopoulos	D-bloc	Technical	Against	Yes
Dimitrakakis	D-bloc	Technical	Against	No
Rontiris	Independent	Distributional	Against	Yes

† Sotiropoulos served as Finance Minister in 1875–76 (hence his pro-government role in §4.1) but was a consistent D-bloc figure; his stance across the full 1875–1885 period is oppositional.

Note: Faction designations use the paper's roll-call coding: T-bloc (Trikoupis), D-bloc (Deligiannis/opposition), and Independent. "Independent" applies to figures whose argumentative register stands apart from their voting bloc, so Deligeorgis (T-bloc by roll-call) and Rontiris (D-bloc by roll-call) appear as Independent. "Economist" follows the classification of parliamentary economists in Psalidopoulos and Syrmaloglou (2005); faction, argument type, and stance coding are this paper's coding from the proceedings. "Gold-first" is an analytical label for support for a gold-unit standard combined with opposition to the 1867 dual-unit/LMU route and to executive implementation. "Gradualist" denotes the named programmatic alternative Deligiannis articulated in December 1883 against Trikoupis's convertibility-through-external-borrowing approach: forced-circulation removal tied to budget condition rather than to external loan issuance. The *Argument type* column reports each speaker's primary register; some speakers operate in additional registers within a single session. Deligeorgis's main 1875 speech, for example, combines constitutional, gold-first, and distributional argumentation, the last concerning working-class harm and habituated prices in dekara and half-drachma units. The within-speaker pattern strengthens rather than weakens the fragmentation reading: even where registers co-occur in one speaker, they remain parallel objections rather than fusing into a programmatic alternative.

and political biography rather than in the transcript's own vocabulary.[101] The figure makes the binary surface clustering visible (see Observation 2 above); the table here carries the fuller five-register coding the fragmentation claim requires. Deligeorgis's constitutional objection to executive implementation of monetary change was logically independent of Zochios's distributional objection, which was in turn independent of Zinopoulos's technical objection that without a balanced budget convertibility could not be sustained. Each argument was individually forceful, but the proceedings examined here do not show them adding up to a programme.

The economist column carries a finding worth pausing on. Of the thirteen parliamentarians coded in Table 1, four are recognised in the prosopography of Psalidopoulos and Syrmaloglou as economists — Sotiropoulos, Deligeorgis, Valassopoulos, and Rontiris — and nine are not.[102] Among the five speakers whose primary register is technical (Sotiropoulos, Zygoma-

101. Deligeorgis, for example, led a party called the National Committee which was real and electorally active, but the label does not appear in the December 1875 proceedings. The T-bloc / D-bloc / Independent coding used in Table 1 is this paper's own analytical reconstruction from those external sources, not a vocabulary drawn from the proceedings. The roll-call analysis itself is the subject of a companion paper in the same thesis project (Paper 3, "Permeable Patronage: Fiscal Crises and Domain-Specific Defection in the Greek Parliament, 1875–1905"), which uses the same digitised Hellenic Parliament corpus to examine domain-specific defection patterns across the longer 1875–1905 period. The two papers complement rather than duplicate: Paper 3 maps voting behaviour, this paper reconstructs argumentative register.

102. On the identification and professional profile of parliamentary economists, see Psalidopoulos and Syrmaloglou, "Economists in the Greek Parliament, 1862–1910: The Men and Their Views on Fiscal and Monetary Policy"; Psalidopoulos, *A History of Modern Greek Economic Thought*, chs. 2–3.

las, Zinopoulos, Valassopoulos, Dimitrakakis), only two are economists; the remaining three are not. Sotiropoulos's own case is richer than the loan arithmetic alone suggests. Psalidopoulos reconstructs him as a civil servant, parliamentarian, finance minister, and later prime minister whose 1861 work on land taxation defended "philanthropic taxation," infrastructure, and peasant education, and treated Ottoman-style gross-production taxation in kind as incompatible with parliamentary democracy because it alienated the countryside from the state.[103] His later parliamentary opposition to plough-animal taxation, and his preference for a modest income tax accepted through simplification of the taxpayer-state relationship, placed fiscal credibility inside an agricultural-constituency frame rather than a banker-centred one.[104] The 1883–1885 critique of loan discounts and banker gains should therefore be read as continuous with a longer view: creditworthiness required expanding productive income and making taxation administratively intelligible, not merely contracting a foreign loan on harsh terms.

This pattern is less paradoxical than it appears once the character of the "economist" designation in this setting is understood. The parliamentary economists of 1862–1910 were, in Psalidopoulos's formulation, "Schumpeter's consultant administrators": mostly practitioners familiar with the business of governing, drawn from the legal profession, the civil service, and banking, whose ideas focused on how to run and manage the short term.[105] The boundary between economist and non-economist was therefore permeable in practice. A lawyer, landowner, or physician who served on the Finance Committee or spoke regularly on fiscal bills acquired technical fluency in public credit, taxation, and monetary circulation without necessarily publishing economic treatises. The debate over the 170 million franc loan and convertibility restoration was framed in precisely these administrative terms: debt sustainability, note circulation, reserve ratios, and the sequencing of metallic backing. Because the government's own defence was presented as a technical operation of public finance, critics were drawn into that register regardless of their prosopographical status. The non-economists Zygomalas, Zinopoulos, and Dimitrakakis attack the proposal with the same instruments — loan-cost calculations, budget projections, convertibility timetables — because these were the instruments available in a chamber whose economic discourse was overwhelmingly practical and administrative.[106] What they could not do — and what distinguishes them from the economists in the table only by degree, not by kind — was convert those technical claims into a rival theoretical architecture or a civilisational counter-narrative. Trikoupis, the architect of the convertibility programme, was himself not an economist on this coding. The asymmetry the rest of the section analyses — that critics offered technical claims unbundled from civilisational narrative while the government bundled

103. Psalidopoulos, 49–50.

104. Psalidopoulos, 57.

105. Psalidopoulos, 59. The professional breakdown: lawyers (the majority), academics (19%), bankers and bank employees (14%), civil servants (11%), landowners (8%), and journalists (4%). Psalidopoulos, 443.

106. This reading is reinforced by the broader pattern Psalidopoulos identifies: "On the monetary front, they supported convertibility, but were shy to recommend the restriction of monetary circulation or the termination of the practice of government loans from the NBG." Psalidopoulos, 59. The critics in 1883–1884 were not shy about the latter, but their objections remained administrative rather than theoretical.

both — is therefore not reducible to a divide between economist critics and non-economist defenders. It is a reflection of how technical-register speech was deployed, not of who could deploy it. The HOPE-relevant question of whether economists carry distinctive monetary argument in this chamber would require the longer-period roll-call and biographical analysis pursued in the companion paper rather than the within-period thirteen-speaker reading offered here.

The significance of this fragmentation, in Morgan's terms, is that successful contestation of a model requires not just logical refutation but a rival working instrument. A counter-model must be able to perform the same functions as the model it contests: it must construct an alternative world, interrogate it, demonstrate it, and narrate it. Four separate objections, each addressing a different dimension of the problem, cannot jointly perform this work unless they are assembled into a shared alternative. The record examined here does not show a figure who combined the constitutional, distributional, regional, technical, and gradualist threads into a coherent alternative account of what Greek monetary policy should look like. Deligiannis came closest, articulating a gradualist alternative on forced-circulation timing, but his framework did not extend to the constitutional, distributional, regional, or technical registers in which other critics had raised objections.

5.4 Observation 4: Vindication did not generate an alternative framework

The fourth observation concerns what happened after the suspension. Several central warnings had been borne out within months. By October 1885, Trikoupis himself, now in opposition, was attacking the system he had built; by December 1885, Dimitrakakis was returning on the floor to the 170 million loan, the coupons, the damage to public credit, and the earlier promise that money would flow back once forced circulation was lifted (Section IV.3). The wider fiscal-fragility reading that the 1893 bankruptcy and the 1898 turn to international financial control would later supply lies beyond this paper's reconstruction. The gold standard experiment, as a parliamentary project, was over.

But empirical confirmation did not supply an alternative. The parliamentary debates of late 1885 were not debates about bimetallism or chartalism or the restructuring of the National Bank's privileges. They were debates about the immediate management of the monetary crisis the gold standard had left behind: the legal status of paper currency, the enforcement of contracts denominated in gold, the distribution of losses. The model's collapse did not create the political space for a counter-model. The absence of a counter-theory after collapse is itself evidence for the paper's claim: even empirical vindication did not turn accurate warnings into a working theory of peripheral gold adoption. Instead, collapse created what might be called a debris problem: the wreckage of one institutional arrangement had to be managed within the only conceptual vocabulary available, which was still substantially the vocabulary of gold standard discourse. Parliament was managing failure, not building alternatives.

Morgan's "travelling facts" framework helps explain this outcome. She observes that when a model travels, it sheds its "caveats and scope conditions": the local knowledge that qualified it in its original setting does not travel with it.[107] In the Greek case, we might add that when a model fails, it does not automatically take its conceptual vocabulary with it.[108] The gold standard model had structured parliamentary discourse for a decade. It had defined what counted as monetary credibility, what counted as a legitimate monetary argument, what counted as progress. Its collapse discredited the specific policy but left intact the underlying framework of evaluation. The critics had been borne out on the immediate operational consequences. They had not built an alternative framework for thinking about monetary policy, and so they had no new conceptual vocabulary ready to deploy.

5.5 The Absent Counter-theory: Bimetallism

The observations converge on a question that the paper has been preparing since Section II: why did no Greek parliamentarian develop bimetallism into a counter-model?

The question has analytical force precisely because bimetallism was a leading available international alternative. As established above, the debate over gold versus silver was being waged vigorously across Europe and the Americas throughout the period of the Greek debates. The silver-gold differential that drove the coinage disputes of 1875–1876, the depreciation of silver in the international markets, the Latin Monetary Union's slow pivot towards de facto gold monometallism – all of these were direct manifestations of the bimetallic controversy. A Greek parliamentarian with access to French financial journalism, or even to the parliamentary debates of France and the United States, would have encountered bimetallism as a serious, intellectually respectable alternative.

And yet the parliamentary record does not show a positive parliamentary defence of it. As established in Section II, what is absent is not bimetallist vocabulary as such — which does appear, in descriptive and polemical registers — but the explicit language of bimetallism as a positive competing framework and any sustained appeal for a silver-standard or bimetallic reconstruction.[109]

107. Morgan, "Travelling Facts," 3–42.

108. Morgan's analysis focuses on the conditions under which models travel from their site of construction. The extension offered here, that a failed model does not dissolve the conceptual vocabulary it had installed, goes beyond what she explicitly argues; it is offered as an inference from the parliamentary record rather than a claim about the framework itself.

109. A read-only corpus audit of the digitised proceedings across 1875–1885 (988 session files spanning sixteen volumes, 100289 to 100304) found no parliamentary intervention advocating bimetallism, a silver standard, or any non-gold metallic framework as a positive programme for Greek monetary policy. The audit was machine-assisted but manually adjudicated: the UTF-8 per-session files were searched in accent-stripped lower-case form for narrow Greek stems and phrase windows connected to bimetallism, silver, gold, monetary systems, and metallic standards, after which each candidate passage was read in its session context. The strongest hits all cut the other way: bimetallism appears descriptively (foreign systems, historical narration, Latin Monetary Union references), polemically (reductios against the government's gold-silver equivalence claim), or anti-bimetallically (positive rejections of the dual unit). Several 1885 "gold or silver" passages turned out to concern contract and loan-payment clauses under forced circulation, not monetary-standard programmes. Two limitations of the audit are documented for transparency. The classification scheme distinguished six categories (descriptive, foreign-comparison, polemical, constitutional, dual-unit-critique, and anti-bimetallist) and was calibrated by representative-example reporting;

The analytically striking finding is therefore not total silence about the silver-gold question. Deligeorgis's December 1875 speeches show that at least one prominent figure had engaged directly with the international controversy: he attacked the "two-unit" structure of the 1867 system, insisted that it had been condemned abroad, and argued that Greece should prefer a gold unit.[110] Zochios's December 1876 proposal to pay salaries and collect taxes partly in gold and partly in silver was likewise not a bimetallist programme but a polemical test of the government's claim that the two metals could be treated as equivalent.[111] The absence is narrower but more precise: no deputy translated awareness of the controversy into a positive Greek bimetallist alternative.

This finding materially strengthens the paper's central claim. The absence of a parliamentary bimetallist programme was not the result of insufficient exposure to international monetary thinking. It was the result of that thinking being processed from within a gold-oriented frame. Even the most analytically sophisticated opponents either sought postponement, constitutional ratification, different sequencing, a more direct gold-unit standard, or, like Zochios, attacked the government's failure to bring genuine gold coin into Greece rather than its commitment to gold. The corpus sweep further surfaced anti-bimetallist voices beyond Deligeorgis: Kalligas in January 1882 treated Greece's continued possession of δύω συστήματα νομισματικά as ἄτοπον and a σολοικισμός (a defect, a solecism to be unified away from), and Trikoupis himself, as early as December 1875, characterised the 1867 dual basis as operative only in legal form: διπλῆ νομισματικὴ βάσις ὑφίσταται μόνον ἐν τῷ γράμματι ('the dual monetary basis subsists only in the letter').[112] By late 1884, the government's anti-bimetallist self-positioning had become explicit enough that Deligiannis, leading the opposition, quoted a semi-official newspaper reporting that the government ἥκιστα ἀρέσκεται εἰς τὸν διμεταλλισμόν ('is least pleased with bimetallism') and intended monometallism.[113] The relevant contestation was about *how* to reach a credible

while no positive-programme hit emerged, the negative finding rests on the calibration's accuracy rather than on an automatic label count. Header OCR in one 1882 volume was sufficiently noisy that a small coverage gap remains within that volume's session boundaries, and OCR noise in polytonic Greek can break names, accents, hyphenated compounds, and numerals even where the underlying text is present. Neither limitation is sufficient to falsify the absence finding, which is consistent with the secondary literature's silence on any Greek bimetallist parliamentary moment.

110. See Section IV.1 above for the verbatim gold-first formulation. Beyond gold-preference, the proceedings show Deligeorgis explicitly characterising the dual unit itself as harmful: ('the double unit was harmful'), with approving reference to states that have ('abolished the silver unit, retaining only that of gold'). Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 61, 11/23 December 1875. The bearing on the bimetallism non-uptake claim is direct: the sharpest analytical opponent of the government's route was not silent on the silver-gold question but was actively anti-bimetallist within the chamber.

111. See Section IV.1 above for the verbatim sources, including Zochios's own retrospective gloss on the proposal's purpose, given at the moment he withdrew the motion at the close of the session.

112. Kalligas, Parliamentary Proceedings (January 1882). Trikoupis, Parliamentary Proceedings, Session 61, 11/23 December 1875. The Trikoupis finding is striking because it shows the future architect of gold-standard adoption articulating, a decade earlier, the case for treating the dual basis as gold-leaning in practice.

113. Deligiannis, Parliamentary Proceedings (late 1884). The exchange is significant because it locates the absence-claim verification right inside the 170 million franc loan debates: the gold standard was not being adopted in Greece against an active bimetallist current but in a chamber where even the opposition leader cited the government's anti-bimetallism approvingly enough to use it polemically.

metallic standard, and under what legal and fiscal conditions, more than about *whether* to move toward gold at all. In Morgan's terms, the counter-model was not merely unavailable – it was foreclosed from within the dominant discourse.

Several structural factors reinforced this closure. The Latin Monetary Union framework may have foreclosed the option practically: Greece was already within the Union's orbit, and unilateral adoption of a silver standard would have disrupted the commercial relationships that the Union had partially stabilised. Greece had no significant silver mining endowment comparable to the American West, which gave US silver advocates a material interest in bimetallic policy. The civilisational narrative may also have been doing its work: bimetallism was increasingly associated, in European discourse, with backward agrarian economies resisting the modernity of gold. To invoke it publicly would have been to accept the government's framing that the critics were the enemies of progress.

Whatever the weight of these structural factors, the primary finding stands. Bimetallism was available as an international language, and the dual-unit controversy was plainly understood. But it was not adopted as a Greek parliamentary programme. In its absence, the critics were left making caveats rather than demonstrations. They had, as it were, accurate warnings about the question Parliament actually debated, but not an answer to the question the dominant model suppressed: what alternative monetary framework would serve Greek conditions? That question rarely reached the chamber in a form that could generate a counter-model.

A second potential counter-narrative deserves brief mention. Georg Friedrich Knapp's *Staatliche Theorie des Geldes* (State Theory of Money),[114] which grounded monetary value in legal designation rather than metallic backing – "*Das Geld ist ein Geschöpf der Rechtsordnung*" (money is a creature of the legal order) – was published in 1905, too late for the debates examined here. The Greek proceedings surveyed here show no comparable state-theory counter-language. The point is simply that the critics' failure to develop a counter-model was not a logical consequence of the later empirical confirmation of several warnings about Greek conditions: predictively accurate objections still had to be assembled into a working alternative justification.

5.6 Alternative Justifications and the Missing "Not Now"

The paper's central claim requires precision: three readings of the critics' position are possible, and they carry different implications.

The first is that the gold standard rested on *wrong theory*: that the underlying monetary economics (quantity theory, specie-flow mechanism) was fundamentally incorrect. This is not the paper's claim. The quantity theory was not wrong; it simply operated in Greece under conditions that frustrated its mechanisms.

114. Georg Friedrich Knapp, *Staatliche Theorie des Geldes*, First edition. English translation by H.M. Lucas and J. Bonar: *The State Theory of Money*. Macmillan, London, 1924. (Leipzig: Duncker & Humblot, 1905).

The second is that the gold standard was the *wrong model*: inherently flawed as an institutional arrangement. This is also not the claim. The gold standard functioned tolerably well in core economies with developed fiscal systems, established capital markets, and strong central banks. Its success elsewhere was not an illusion.

The paper's claim is a third. The critics did not need a counter-theory to argue against gold adoption in 1882–1885; what they needed was access to a justification that the dominant frame had foreclosed. Several such justifications were live in international monetary discourse of the period — and several appeared, in fragmented form, in the Greek chamber itself — but none acquired the discursive standing to count as a serious alternative. They sort into four:

- *Not now.* Delay gold adoption until the fiscal preconditions identified by Greek deputies (balanced budget, stabilised note issue, settled monetary unit) had been met. This was the natural extension of Zinopoulos's budget-balance precondition and of Sotiropoulos's loan-terms critique, but no parliamentarian articulated it as a positive timing programme.

- *Reform first.* Restructure the National Bank's dual role as note-issuer and treasury agent, and place monetary action on a more secure constitutional footing, before tying convertibility to a regime that assumed those reforms had been carried through. This is implicit in the constitutional and procedural objections of Deligeorgis and others but was never named as a sequencing programme.

- *Different sequence.* Stabilise the LMU bimetallic implementation that had been delayed since 1867 before pivoting to gold monometallism. The international drift towards de facto gold monometallism after 1873 made this politically dead, but the late date of effective Greek minting under LMU parity (November 1882) shows the option remained structurally available.

- *Different unit.* Adopt a gold-first standard directly, abandoning the 1867 dual-unit framework, on the model Deligeorgis attributed to states that had "abolished the silver unit, retaining only that of gold." Of the four, this was the only alternative articulated as a positive parliamentary programme — and it pushed *toward* gold rather than away from it.

What is striking about this list is what it omits. None of the timing-, sequencing-, or reform-based alternatives was advanced by a parliamentarian as the positive Greek monetary programme. The "not now" argument was the closest fit to the deputies' precondition-articulation, but it lacked an institutional voice: no faction adopted timing as its central frame, and no speaker carried the warning forward into a programme of staged adoption. The dominant justification — "now, gold, fully" — prevailed not because the alternatives were demonstrated to fail, but because they were never assembled into propositions the chamber could vote on. In Morgan's terms, the model's authority operated less by defeating rival programmes than by foreclosing the discursive space in which those programmes could have been formulated.

This reframing matters for how we evaluate the critics' arguments. As the section opener distinguished, the paper's two claims are evidentially asymmetric. The well-supported claim is precondition-articulation: critics named the institutional and fiscal preconditions that the model required and that Greek conditions did not supply, and the 1875–1885 archive shows them doing so register by register through the decade. The more contestable claim is theoretical-superiority: that the critics possessed a sounder monetary theory than the government. That stronger claim remains harder to defend. A parliamentarian who warned that gold standards always fail would have been wrong. The defensible formulation is that many critics were locally and accurately tracking Greece's missing preconditions, even if this paper has not demonstrated that they held a complete alternative monetary theory. The predictive vindication of 1885, and the deeper vindication that 1893 and 1898 would later supply, support the precondition-articulation claim without exhausting it. The circumstances the critics identified — and the alternative justifications that would have given those circumstances programmatic form — were precisely what the model's civilisational framing rendered invisible, including, most pointedly, the live possibility that the right answer in 1882–1885 was *not now*.

6 Why the Critics Lost

Why did predictively accurate arguments fail to persuade? The Greek case extends Morrison's argument from the British core to the European periphery. British orthodoxy rested on confused technical beliefs about the classical gold standard's automaticity; Greek orthodoxy rested on imported technical beliefs about what gold adoption would do for a fiscally fragile peripheral state. The decisive feature is epistemic heteronomy: the terms of technical credibility were set outside the Greek parliament, by European precedent, creditor expectations, and the prestige of gold. The critics lost because they lacked both a counter-narrative and a counter-theory capable of explaining how peripheral gold adoption could work, or why it could not, under Greek conditions. Within that frame, Morgan's framework illuminates the specific asymmetry in model authority that structured the parliamentary contests. The gold standard model carried autonomous authority from its construction, built from heterogeneous materials including the quantity theory of money, the Latin Monetary Union treaties, British monetary precedent, and decades of diplomatic pressure from European powers.[115] No single theoretical source fully determined its content, and this hybrid origin gave the model an internal logic that could be "run" to produce demonstrations: in this case, the demonstration that gold adoption would produce stabilising effects and European creditworthiness. The critics, by contrast, offered arguments without this autonomous demonstration capacity. They could point to fiscal instability, but they could not "run" an alternative model showing how a different monetary framework would

115. M. Morrison, "Models as Autonomous Agents," 38–65.

produce superior outcomes.

This asymmetry deepened through narrative embedding. Trikoupis framed gold as the prerequisite for bringing Greece into line with the other civilised states, linking a technical-and-civilisational bundle to a story about Greek national identity. Morgan's work shows that narratives function as "cognitive bridges" between the abstract model and the concrete economic world.[116] The gold standard model did not just promise price stability; it promised that Greece would become the kind of nation that could command international respect, access European capital markets, and take its place among modern states. The critics' technical, constitutional, and distributional fragments lacked comparable bundling. They told Greeks what they would lose, not how a different monetary sequence would let Greece become creditworthy under its own conditions.

The parliamentary debates thus illustrate what Morgan calls the "travelling facts" problem: technical knowledge that succeeds in one setting may lose its "caveats and scope conditions" when it moves to another.[117] The gold standard model had been constructed in Britain, France, and other core economies. It "travelled" to Greece carrying the authority of European economic science. But the "woolly details", to use Morgan's phrase, of Greek fiscal weakness, regional variation, and constitutional tradition were precisely what the model shed as it travelled. The critics articulated these local conditions. The model's authority made them seem like friction to be overcome, not information to be incorporated.

Most critically, the critics lacked what Morgan calls a "counter-model". In *The World in the Model*, she argues that successful scientific contestation typically requires not just logical refutation but a rival working object that can demonstrate alternative possibilities.[118] The Greek critics had arguments and, in places, technically valid claims about constitutional sequence (Deligeorgis on the order in which monetary reform should follow rather than precede fiscal repair), regional equity (Vellanitis on the Ionian islands and Papamichalopoulos on basic-necessity exemptions from customs conversion), debt sustainability (Sotiropoulos on the 1883 loan terms, Valassopoulos on the eve-of-crisis magnitudes, Dimitrakakis on the post-suspension loan, coupon, and public-credit consequences), monetary crisis escalation (Balsamakis on the 10–50 percent depreciation range and the prospect of ἄπειροι δίκαι), and the fragility of convertibility (Zinopoulos on the budget-balance precondition). They did not have a counter-theory of peripheral gold adoption that could rival Trikoupis's technical-and-civilisational bundle with the same demonstrative capacity. They were, in Morgan's terms, arguing at Step 4 (narrative contestation) against an opponent who controlled Steps 1–3 (model construction, interrogation, demonstration). The asymmetry was decisive.

This counter-model claim needs to be defended against weaker readings the case is also consistent with. Fragmentation hurt the critics; civilisational framing did persuasive work; LMU

116. Morgan, *The World in the Model: How Economists Work and Think*, 244.
117. Morgan, "Travelling Facts," 3–42; Sugden, "Mary S. Morgan's *The World in the Model*: How Economists Work and Think"; Halsmayer, "Review of *The World in the Model*, by Mary S. Morgan."
118. Morgan, *The World in the Model: How Economists Work and Think*, esp. ch. 10.

membership constrained alternatives. The chamber arithmetic alone does not force the strong reading: a 107–85 vote on the 1880 forced-circulation principle could plausibly have been flipped by coordinated whipping across the five argumentative registers, without anyone constructing a counter-theory. What distinguishes the strong reading is the bimetallism non-uptake examined in Section V above. A fragmentation account predicts that the counter-programme would have appeared in the proceedings and failed to coalesce; a civilisational-framing account predicts that it would have been raised and rhetorically defeated. Neither predicts the finding established there: that bimetallism produced no positive Greek parliamentary programme, and that even the sharpest analytical opponent of the government's route, Deligeorgis, pushed *toward* gold rather than away from it. The dominant counter-programme was not contested or defeated; it was foreclosed from within the discourse the model had structured. That is the specifically Morgan-shaped finding the weaker readings cannot reach.

The gold standard model did not merely describe Greek monetary policy; it helped constitute what counted as a legitimate parliamentary argument. When Trikoupis framed gold adoption as a civilisational imperative, he made distributional objections seem provincial, even unpatriotic. The model's narrative authority performed "categorical displacement" and rendered certain kinds of objections illegible within the dominant frame.[119]

7 Conclusion

The Greek case illuminates what happens when models meet institutions. The gold standard was not a self-enforcing commitment mechanism that Greece simply failed to follow. It was a model that required parliamentary mediation in the form of assent, legitimacy, and political support, none of which was ever fully secured.

The parliamentary proceedings recover arguments that aggregate data and published treatises obscure: regional equity, constitutional sequence, distributional burden, and even rival intuitions about monetary fit. These were not backward objections from politicians who failed to understand monetary economics. They were situated knowledge claims about the costs of monetary transformation that the travelling model systematically shed.

Morgan's framework clarifies why these arguments lost. The gold standard combined autonomous authority, technical claims about creditworthiness, and a civilisational narrative about what Greece would become. Critics challenged parts of the apparatus, and sometimes proposed alternatives in fragments, but they never assembled a rival counter-theory capable of demonstrating a different monetary future with comparable force.

For monetary history, the implication is straightforward: parliamentary proceedings are not supplementary sources but central evidence for how economic ideas are received, contested, and transformed in legislative arenas. For Morgan's framework, the point is equally important.

119. Arturo Escobar, *Encountering Development: The Making and Unmaking of the Third World* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1995); Kostis, *History's Spoiled Children: The Formation of the Modern Greek State.*

Applying "models as mediators" to parliamentary settings reveals that models gain political authority under asymmetric institutional conditions, not in a vacuum.

The analysis stops at 1885, but the questions it raises extend beyond it.[120] Whether the collapse of convertibility in 1885 and the sovereign bankruptcy of 1893 eventually generated the counter-model that was absent from the earlier debates remains an open question for future research. The bankruptcy did not by itself produce the International Financial Commission: the decisive sequence ran through continued fiscal crisis, the 1897 defeat and indemnity, and then international financial control in 1898. Parliamentary debate in the 1890s and beyond shifted from monetary theory towards debt management and fiscal adjustment. Whether this transition from money management to debt management discourse displaced the gold standard's civilisational narrative or merely replaced it with a different form of external constraint is a question that extended archival work in the post-1886 proceedings could answer. Italy offers one comparative reference point because it shared with Greece membership in the Latin Monetary Union, repeated episodes of inconvertible paper currency, and difficulty sustaining gold-standard commitments; a fuller comparison would need to set that monetary history alongside Italy's domestic political-economy and parliamentary institutions.[121]

This paper sits within a larger thesis project on peripheral debt, supervision, and parliamentary politics during the first globalisation. The gold-standard debates reconstructed here open the fiscal sequence the rest of the thesis follows: foreign borrowing, restored convertibility, suspension, default, military defeat, and external fiscal control. A companion paper using the same digitised Hellenic Parliament corpus examines the longer 1875–1905 period through roll-call analysis, asking how fiscal crisis reshaped patronage discipline rather than how monetary arguments acquired or lost authority. The two papers complement methodologically: legislative behaviour and parliamentary argument under the same institutional setting and source base. The bond-pricing chapters of the thesis, in turn, supply the market-side counterpart to the parliamentary politics analysed here, tracing how creditor supervision changed the pricing and ranking of Greek sovereign debt across the same period. The reading offered in this paper articulates with that wider project: the gold standard was adopted under a justification ("now, gold, fully") that suppressed the timing-, sequencing-, and reform-first alternatives the critics implicitly carried, and the political and market consequences of that suppression unfold across the chapters that follow.

The Greek case also poses a question that remains open: why, when subsequent events bore out several of the critics' warnings, did they still not prevail? By October 1885, the convertibil-

120. The cutoff at the September 1885 suspension is a deliberate methodological choice. The paper's contribution rests primarily on what the 1875–1885 archive can establish about parliamentary articulation of preconditions, rather than on a corpus-wide predictive vindication that would require extension to the 1893 bankruptcy and the 1898 International Financial Commission. The 1885 evidence supplies an immediate empirical test of the critics' warnings; the deeper structural vindication that 1893 and 1898 supply is acknowledged in the framing but not reconstructed in this paper.

121. Morys, "The Gold Standard, Fiscal Dominance and Financial Supervision in Greece and South-East Europe, 1841–1939."

ity project had been suspended and Trikoupis himself was managing its emergency aftermath. The 1893 bankruptcy and the 1898 turn to international financial control — both outside this paper's reconstruction — would later supply structural confirmation that the immediate 1885 evidence only partially carries. Several warnings about forced circulation, fiscal imbalance, and the loan's burden had been borne out in their immediate operational form, though not thereby proven as a complete alternative monetary theory. Yet even this immediate confirmation did not itself supply an alternative monetary programme, a political coalition, or a counter-theory of peripheral gold adoption. The critics had been borne out on the immediate operational consequences. They had not articulated what Greece could become, and they had not articulated how a fiscally fragile peripheral state could sequence credit, convertibility, borrowing, and monetary management. That loss, the Greek case suggests, was the work of models not just as representations of economies but as instruments of political transformation.

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